



Hindustan Times

Chandra to step down as Tata Sons chair at end of his term

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BENGALURU/MUMBAI: After a 40-year association with the Tata Group, Natarajan Chandrasekaran on Wednesday said he had decided to step down as chairman of Tata Sons when his current term ends, citing lack of unanimous support for his reappointment from the board of the holding company of the salt-to-software conglomerate.

Shares of the group's listed companies lost \$4.5 billion in market value after the announcement. Tata Consultancy Services slumped 3.9% and was the biggest loser on the Nifty, dragging benchmark indexes lower. Jaguar Land Rover-parent Tata Motors Passenger Vehicles closed down 1.3%, while jeweller Titan and

"It is not only necessary to have a leader in place to lead the Group beyond Feb 2027, but also clarity on leadership is important for employees, investors, partners and other stakeholders. Under these circumstances, earlier today, I have communicated to the Tata Sons Board, that I have decided not to offer myself for reappointment when my term ends on Feb 20, 2027."

— **NATARAJAN CHANDRASEKARAN,**
outgoing chairman, Tata Sons

mint

Tata Steel slipped 0.6% and 1.1%, respectively.

The decision came days before the Tata Sons annual general meeting, scheduled for 18 August, and caught Tata Trusts chairman Noel Tata and most of the trustees off guard, two executives aware of the development

said. Tata Trusts owns 65.9% of Tata Sons.

On Wednesday evening, Chandrasekaran called about two dozen senior Tata Group executives to Starbucks on the ground floor of Bombay House, the corporate headquarters of Tata Sons, according to people aware of the development.

In a 20-minute pep talk, he sought to assuage concerns

among employees, telling them that Tata was a revered name with a strong talent pool. He signed off by telling them not to take the interaction as his farewell speech, as he would remain with the Tata Group until February.

Chandrasekaran, who was first appointed chairman of Tata Sons in February 2017, began a second five-year term in 2022. His current term ends on 20 February 2027.

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Tata's succession planning on test →P2

Chandra's stint at Tata: A tale of two halves →P2

Group's market cap tripled under outgoing chair →P2

BANK OF AMERICA TO ACQUIRE 49.9% STAKE IN JIO CREDIT FOR ₹18,268 CRORE

BENGALURU: Jio Financial Services and Bank of America on Wednesday announced that the US-based lender will acquire a 49.9% stake in the Mukesh Ambani-promoted company's lending arm, Jio Credit, for \$1.9 billion or ₹18,268 crore.

NB Holdings, a BoA subsidiary, will pick up 42.9 million equity shares for cash through a preferential issue for up to ₹603 crore to pick up a 26.5% stake, and follow it up by subscribing to 75.6 million warrants for a consideration of ₹1,655 crore. Each warrant will be convertible into an equity share within 18 months. **PTI**

{ **KANWAR YATRA** }

Haridwar grapples with 7k-tonne waste pile-up

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HARIDWAR: The holy city of Haridwar is dealing with the after-effects of the Kanwar yatra, tonnes of waste lying in parking lots, camps, and even the Ganga ghats (bathing areas). According to Haridwar's municipal town commissioner Nandan Kumar, around 7,000 tonnes of garbage was generated in the two weeks of the Kanwar yatra, when pilgrims from across north India travel to the city to pick up Ganga water, which they then transport

back, without stopping or in a relay, to their villages.

The city administration, used to dealing with around 250 tonnes of garbage, is now clearing mounds of clothes, plastic bottles, and other waste.

In recent years, the yatra has become increasingly popular, and also loud, with pilgrims driving into town on trucks rigged with giant speakers. This year, according to Kumar, around 10 million pilgrims visited Haridwar on just Sunday and Monday, the last two days of the yatra. All told, 48 million pilgrims did. **→P7**

BEANT SINGH MURDER CONVICT DECLINES TWO-DAY CUSTODY PAROLE

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NEW DELHI/CHANDIGARH: Former Punjab chief minister Beant Singh's assassination convict Jagtar Singh Hawara on Wednesday declined the Delhi prisons department's two-day custody parole grant to meet his ailing octogenarian mother, as he sought regular parole, said people familiar with the matter. The development came hours after Punjab CM Bhagwant Mann met governor Gulab Chand Kataria to push for 10-day parole for Hawara. **→P5**



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- नीव** Foundational literacy for young children (Vadodara, GJ)

- SAMAVESH** Education access for migrant children (Pune, MH)
- स्वर्ग** Ending menstrual isolation (Gadchiroli, MH)
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Migration's economics and politics in US, Europe and China

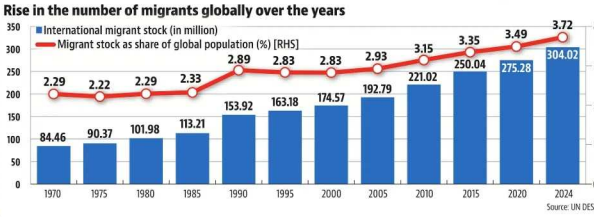
By Sreedev Krishnakumar

Elon Musk, the world's richest man and an immigrant to America, believes Europe is a cesspool of illegal migration and the UK is on the brink of a civil war because of it. Back home, he supported President Donald Trump's tough stance on illegal migration but opposed his restrictive policies on the migration of high-skilled workers. The veracity of Musk's claims notwithstanding, Europe continues to debate migration, as was seen during the dramatic episode of thousands of Moroccans illegally crossing into Spanish territory of Ceuta recently, only to be pushed back. All of this is happening as the world's other economic superpower, China, has achieved economic might without having to allow a significant number of in-migrants. The numbers are worth looking at in detail.



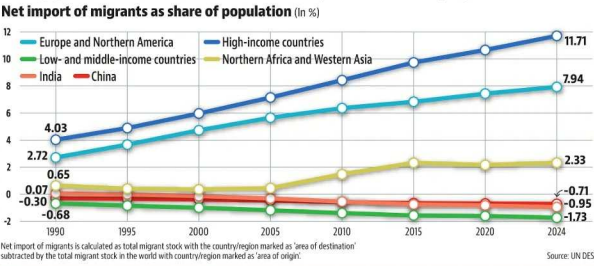
1 Migrants are still a small share of world's population...

International migration has grown from a demographic footnote into a political fault-line. The number of people living outside their country of birth or citizenship rose from 84 million in 1970 to 304 million in 2024, an increase of 260%. Over the same period, the world's population grew by 121%, from 3.7 billion to 8.2 billion. Yet the scale should not be overstated. Migrants increased from 2.3% to just 3.7% of the global population.



2 Countries exporting and importing migrants vary drastically

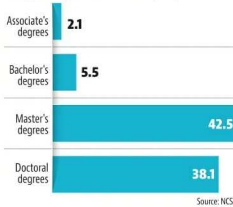
The headline share of migrants might not be a good indicator of why it is so debated politically. Migration's political weight is amplified by where it is concentrated. Europe and Northern America hosted 155 million migrants in 2024, more than half the global stock, despite accounting for only around 14% of the world's population. The difference is even more pronounced if one were to compare countries by number of migrants they host and export across the world. If one were to compare countries by their net import of migrants adjusted for population, European and North American ones stand out even more. Countries like China and India are on the other extreme: they have sent far too many migrants than host them.



3 Where Europe and US differ: The migrants they want

America's economic and strategic might would not be what it is without migrants. From slaves shipped in to do forced labour on plantations to Europe's knowledge elite fleeing Nazi persecution to the new wave of Asian migrants – primarily from India and China – becoming important stakeholders in US's financial and technology leadership at present, the story has had different acts but the same impact. Trump wants to change all that by putting a prohibitively high fees on \$100,000 on foreign graduates of American universities who want to work in the US. This follows a similar, now withdrawn, levy, on H-1B visas. The costs of doing this could be really high. Almost four in ten of US's science and engineering masters and PhD degree holders are foreigners. Europeans seem to be more pragmatic and are happy to welcome migrants who are high-skilled or looking to become high-skilled but not those who are unskilled or just asylum seekers.

Share of science and engineering degrees in the US awarded to temporary visa holders (in %)



How views of migrant groups vary across European countries

Share of respondents who expressed a completely or somewhat positive view of each migrant group (%)

	France	Germany	Denmark	Spain	Italy
Doctors on work visas	62	71	71	71	61
Foreign university students	56	60	42	72	68
Unskilled workers on work visas	40	43	51	59	38
Unskilled workers without valid visas	14	17	13	25	11
Irregular asylum seekers	11	8	10	18	8
People described as coming to claim benefits	6	5	4	6	7

The surveys were conducted between November 11 to 24, 2025. Source: YouGov

How will the US and Europe resolve their political debate on migration? Will these mutate into cultural wars as the likes of Musk and the neo-right political formations he supports in Europe are saying or will democratically elected governments find a way to strike a balance? Will China carve out an exception in the world where a country achieves economic dominance without opening its doors to a large number of skilled as well as unskilled workers from other parts of the world? For India, one of the largest migrants exporting countries in the world and also the largest recipient of remittances, these are not just theoretical questions. They are deeply linked to its economic future.



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WAS GIVEN SLEEP MEDS BY DOCTOR, PILOT TELLS AAIB

NEW DELHI: The commander of the Air India Phuket-Delhi flight that lost altitude on August 4 told investigators he had been struggling with sleep and was on medication prescribed by his family doctor, two people familiar with his account to the Aircraft Accident Investigation Bureau (AAIB) said. —PT

NO MARATHI, NO CAB LICENCE, SAYS MAHA GOVT ORDER

MUMBAI: Starting August 18, the licences of all commercial vehicle drivers in Maharashtra who lack a working knowledge of Marathi will be suspended for up to three months, and repeated violations could lead to licence cancellation, officials said. —PT

TWO DELHI DISTRICT COURTS DENIED FIRE SAFETY CLEARANCE

NEW DELHI: Fire safety clearances for the Dwarka and Karkardooma district court complexes have been held back after inspections by the Delhi Fire Service (DFS) found multiple deficiencies, officials said.

FCRA Bill sent to JPC, Oppn rebuffs Shah

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NEW DELHI: A bill proposing controversial amendments to India's foreign contribution law was referred to a 31-member joint committee of Parliament on Wednesday amid a standoff between the government and the Opposition and repeated disruptions in the House.

The penultimate day of the monsoon session began with Union home minister Amit Shah saying he was ready for a discussion on students' protests and police action, only for the Opposition — which has been demanding his statement in the House and another debate on the Ram Temple donation row — to rebuff the offer.

"Prime Minister Narendra Modi-led NDA government is ready for discussions. The House should be allowed to run, the Opposition should submit a letter to the speaker by 2pm today. We are ready to start discussion at 3pm today," Shah said in a rare media interaction outside Parliament.

Shah also wrote to Lok Sabha speaker Om Birla conveying the

Stand-off script

The House should be allowed to run, the Opposition should submit a letter to the speaker by 2pm today (Wednesday). We are ready to start at 3pm today. — AMIT SHAH, Union home minister

The Opposition has said we are not interested in Amit Shah giving us a lecture. When I say 'we', I mean the younger generation... For the last 20 days, Shah has been missing. — RAHUL GANDHI, Lok Sabha LoP

COMPOSITION OF THE JPC

The 31-member JPC will comprise 21 Lok Sabha members and 10 Rajya Sabha members. A BJP member is expected to lead the panel.

government's readiness to participate in the discussion, only for Congress leader Rahul Gandhi to call it a "last-minute attempt" and say that the Opposition was not interested in listening to Shah's lecture.

The monsoon session is set to end on Thursday. The government indicated that it will not be extended and added that the Opposition's views will be sought.

Introduced in the previous session but held back at the time, the Foreign Contribution (Regulation) Amendment Bill triggered major controversy

with the Opposition, several church delegations and three chief ministers of Christian-majority states raising concerns.

Minister of state for home affairs Nityanand Rai — and not Shah, as originally listed in — continued on —PT

morestories

Lower House clears minerals bill —PT

Pari okays bill to rename Kerala —PT

Ruckus in RS over BJP MP's attire remarks —PT

RETAIL INFLATION STAYS BROADLY FLAT AT 4.45% IN JULY

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NEW DELHI: Retail inflation was flat in India between June and July, barely changing from 4.38% in June to 4.45% in July. This vindicates the position of Reserve Bank of India's Monetary Policy Committee, which ruled out any widespread inflation pressure in the economy in its meeting held last week. The plateauing of retail inflation numbers follows a continuous rise in monthly inflation numbers in the new series, which has a base year of 2024. —PT

M.P. TO SHORE UP MEASURES AGAINST CHAMBAL MINING

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BHOPAL: Madhya Pradesh will deploy over 100 armed guards, permanent check posts and a surveillance system to protect the Chambal Wildlife Sanctuary from illegal sand mining, officials said on Wednesday. By September, we will set up 16 permanent check posts, install 35 CCTV cameras, and an AI monitoring system at 44 sensitive ghats," said Shyam Singh, superintendent of Chambal Wildlife Sanctuary. —PT

Yamuna buffer eroded in Delhi's latest master plan

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NEW DELHI: The Delhi Development Authority (DDA) on Wednesday approved the Master Plan for Delhi-2047 (MPD-2047), which relaxes protections for one chunk of the Yamuna floodplain, allows commercial construction in 70 villages on the edges of the Capital and permits reconstruction and redevelopment of old two-storey DDA units. The plan — which sets out a

long-term framework for the Capital's housing, mobility, infrastructure, environment and economic development — will now be sent to the Union ministry of housing and urban affairs (MoHUA) for final approval and subsequent notification.

With Delhi's population projected to grow significantly by 2047, the Master Plan adopts an integrated approach towards housing, economic growth, mobility, environment — continued on —PT

COMMERCIAL BOOST FOR 70 DELHI VILLAGES

Around 70 villages on Delhi's periphery are likely to be opened up to regulated commercial and institutional development under a new 'Green Development Area (GDA) framework' which is part of the Delhi Development Authority's (DDA) Master Plan for Delhi-2047. HT has learnt. Officials aware of the matter said the framework will 'regulate development', rather than simply open the villages to unrestricted construction.

Charges against Justice Varma proved: LS panel

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NEW DELHI: The three-member parliamentary inquiry committee probing allegations against Allahabad High Court judge Justice Yashwant Varma has found all three articles of charge against him proved, holding that his explanations over the discovery of a substantial stash of currency notes at

his official residence in March 2025 were "evasive and misleading", that his defense was "false" and he failed to discharge his institutional responsibility to preserve material evidence.

In findings that stop short of holding that the cash belonged to Justice Varma, the committee nevertheless rejected his central defence that he had no — continued on —PT

LANDSLIDE STRIKES KURLA TENEMENTS, CLAIMS SEVEN LIVES

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MUMBAI: At least seven people, including four members of a family, were killed and seven others sustained injuries after a landslide struck tenements in Mumbai's Kurla area on Wednesday, officials said.

Officials said the incident took place amid rains, with the landslide destroying four homes and damaging three others. —PT

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MY INDIA | ARUNACHAL TENSIONS

Border situation with India is stable: China



China on Wednesday sought to play down reports of a military standoff with India in the Arunachal Pradesh sector of the Line of Actual Control (LAC), with a foreign ministry spokesman saying the "border situation is generally stable". The comments by Chinese foreign ministry spokesperson Guo Jiakun came a day after the external affairs ministry said that the state of border affairs has improved for overland India-China ties, and that the two sides have agreed to use diplomatic and military mechanisms to "avoid misunderstanding and miscalculation" along the border. The Indian side has officially offered no clarity on the current status of the standoff in Arunachal Pradesh sector, though people familiar with the situation said on condition of anonymity that problems first emerged in the remote Taksing area of Upper Subansiri district in early July and there had been several face-offs between Indian and Chinese troops.

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MY INDIA | INVITE TO PM RAHMAN

B'desh yet to respond to India's Brics invite



The Bangladesh government is yet to convey its formal acceptance of India's invitation to PM Tarique Rahman to attend the Brics Summit next month amid a recent downturn in bilateral relations, people familiar with the matter said. The Bangladesh PM was invited to the Brics Summit to be held in New Delhi during September 12-13 in his capacity as the current chair of the Brics grouping. India's envoy Dinesh Trivedi is understood to have reiterated the invitation at a meeting with Rahman in Dhaka on August 10. With a month to go for the summit, the Bangladesh side is yet to inform India about its acceptance of the invitation, the people familiar with preparations for the event said on condition of anonymity. Similarly, the people said, there has been no word from Dhaka so far on the India's invitation to Rahman for a bilateral visit.

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WORLD | FIRST IN DECADES

Solar eclipse casts darkness in several parts of Europe



One of nature's greatest spectacles — a rare total solar eclipse — cast its shadow on Wednesday, briefly turning day into night in Russia's remote Arctic north before heading towards mainland Europe. The Moon first blotted out the Sun at the northernmost tip of mainland Russia at about 5pm GMT, leaving only the shimmering glow of its outer corona, and eerie darkness. As the eclipse raced south towards parts of Greenland and Iceland, excitement built in Spain, where its narrow path cuts from the northwestern Atlantic coast to the Mediterranean Sea, before being expected to fade at about 6.30pm GMT. Mainland Europe has not experienced a total solar eclipse for 20 years, and tourists and enthusiasts thronged normally quiet villages in Spain, which has not witnessed one in more than a century. Iceland's capital, Reykjavik, has not seen a total solar eclipse since 1433. The event presents scientists with a rare opportunity to study the Sun's atmosphere and its outermost layer, as they seek to uncover secrets about solar winds and our star's magnetic field.

AFP

MY INDIA | DIRECTIVE TO RIDE APPS

No tip prompts before ride completion: Govt



The Union ministry of road transport and highways (MoRTH) has directed ride-sharing aggregators to remove tipping prompts or in-app features that appear before a ride is completed, saying such mechanisms could improperly influence passengers' decisions and create an impression that paying extra could improve service. The directive, issued on Tuesday, follows the ministry's attention being drawn to prompts displayed by aggregators, including "Advance Tip" and "Choose an Add-on", and messages suggesting that a tip could improve the chances of quicker ride confirmation or driver acceptance. "Tipping shall be entirely voluntary and shall be offered only after completion of the journey," the ministry said. It also specified that the entire tip amount must be credited to the driver without any deduction by the aggregator.

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BUSINESS | PRICIER MOBILE BILLS

Airtel drops base tier mobile prepaid plans



A year after the last major pricing revision, indirect tariff hikes have returned to the Indian telecom market, driven by Bharti Airtel. The Sunil Bhatti-led carrier has removed its entry-level T299 monthly prepaid plan that offered 1GB of data per day. To get a daily data allowance for 28 days, subscribers must now upgrade to the T349 plan, marking a ₹50 (16.7%) increase for an offering that includes 15GB of daily data and unlimited 5G access. Separately, Airtel also removed its ₹319 (30-day), ₹579, ₹619, and ₹649 prepaid plans. The development comes at a time when analysts have said that the only way for telcos to improve average revenue per user (ARPU) would be to increase tariffs at regular intervals. "Airtel's withdrawal of the T299 and T349 plans is its first significant move in the current cycle to raise prepaid ARPU. It is not a conventional tariff hike because... it forces users into a higher minimum spend," said independent telecom analyst Parag Kar.

HTC

Inflation holds steady despite food, fuel stress

Roshan Kishore

letters@hindustantimes.com

NEW DELHI: Retail inflation was flat in Delhi between June and July, barely changing from 4.38% in June to 4.45% in July. This vindicates the position of RBI's Monetary Policy Committee (MPC), which ruled out any widespread inflation pressure in the economy in its meeting held last week. The latest inflation reading is also in line with analysts' expectations. A Bloomberg poll of economists expected this number to be 4.5%. The plateauing of retail inflation numbers, as measured by the annual change in Consumer Price Index (CPI), follows a continuous rise in monthly data in the new inflation series which has been year of 2024. Data from the Centre for Monitoring Indian Economy (CMIE) shows that inflation fell to a near-zero level (0.04%) in October 2025 and has risen every month since to 4.45% in July.

Most of the recent increase in inflation has been in food and fuel prices, as can be seen in the trends in core and non-core inflation.

Core inflation measures the non-food non-fuel part of the CPI basket and is immune to seasonal fluctuations. According to CMIE data, core inflation in July 2026 was 4%, the same as in June and not very high from the 3.3% in January. The earliest period for which data is available in the new series. Non-core inflation, on the other hand, increased from 1.9% in January to 5.1% in July. Food inflation increased from 2.1% to 5.2% between January and July.

Food items have a 36% weight in the new CPI basket. While fuel is a consolidated category in CPI data, it has nevertheless seen an increase in inflation because of the war in West Asia. LPG and PNG inflation (with a combined weight of 1.98%) has increased from 1.7% in January to 5% in July.

Fuels and lubricants for personal transport equipment (this category includes petrol, diesel, and CNG with a combined weight of 4.85%) has seen inflation increase from 0.07% in January to 7.55% in July. To be sure, June and July numbers for personal transport fuels are almost exactly the same and likely to continue at almost the same level as prices are lower. This is because petrol and diesel prices were flat in 2025 and saw hikes in instalments that started ended in May 2026.

MPC's latest forecast, which was released earlier this month, expects annual CPI inflation to be 5% in 2026-27 with quarterly values being 4.7%, 5.9% and 5.3% in the quarters ending September 2026, December 2026 and March 2027. Inflation for the June quarter came at 4.3%, which was 30 basis points (one basis point is one hundredth of a percentage point) lower than RBI estimate.

"As increases in inflation continues to be driven by food and administered price increases, we expect the MPC to look through these higher inflation outcomes and persist with a pause for the remainder of 2026," Asstt. Govt. Chief India Economist at Barclays said in a note.

The committee said that shared access to the store room not be equated with ownership, pointing out that the room formed part of the judge's official residential premises and was sufficiently connected with the judge's official premises, is significant. The distinction it draws between physical ownership of the cash and institutional ownership of the cash, and accountability for the premises.

The panel expressly said it was not inferring that the currency notes belonged to Justice Yashwant Varma, nor was it treating the existence of a locked iron cabinet in the store room as proof that he possessed the cash.

But it rejected his claim that the store room was outside his control.

The committee noted that Justice Varma himself had stated that a liquor cabinet containing personal articles was maintained in a space which is wholly unregulated, wholly outside the knowledge of the occupant, or wholly beyond his effective control," the report said.

The committee said that shared access to the store room not be equated with ownership, pointing out that the room formed part of the judge's official residential premises and was sufficiently connected with the judge's official premises, is significant. The distinction it draws between physical ownership of the cash and institutional ownership of the cash, and accountability for the premises.

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MY BENGALURU

Rebalancing act: K'taka CM shifts portfolios to ministers

Arun Dev
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BENGALURU: Karnataka chief minister D K Shivakumar on Wednesday allocated portfolios to 19 ministers inducted into his cabinet on August 3, ending weeks of uncertainty over their responsibilities a day before the state legislature's monsoon session.

The allocation followed discussions between Shivakumar and the Congress high command. The chief minister had visited the national capital on Sunday to meet AICC president Mallikarjun Kharge and party general secretary (organisation) K C Venugopal.

The sanctioned strength of Karnataka's council of ministers is 34, including the chief minister.

With 33 ministers now in place, one berth remains vacant. The cabinet has no woman minister, despite pressure within the party to ensure representation for women.

Shivakumar has retained Finance, Cabinet Affairs, Department of Personnel and Administrative Reforms, Intelligence, Law, and other unallocated departments.

Among the major changes, Ramalinga Reddy has been shifted from Major and Medium Irrigation to Forest, Ecology and Environment after seeking a change of portfolio. N Chaluvaraj has taken over Water Resources, including Major and Medium Irrigation.

K H Muniyappa has been inducted from Food, Civil Supplies and Consumer Affairs to Social Welfare. U T Khader, who was earlier assigned Health and Family Welfare, has been given additional charge of Ministry Welfare, Haj and Waqf.

B Nagendra, who is facing allegations in connection with the alleged embezzlement of funds in the Karnataka Mahashila Vaidiki ST Development Corporation, has been assigned Planning and Statistics. The opposition BJP has been demanding his resignation over the case.

Five ministers have retained



The latest allocation follows Shivakumar's appointment as chief minister on June 3, when he was sworn in along with 13 ministers after former chief minister Siddaramaiah handed in his resignation on May 28, after a long period of speculation.

their portfolios: B Z Zameer Ahmed Khan (Housing), Shivaraj Tangadagi (Backward Classes Welfare and Kannada and Culture), Madhu Bangarappa (Primary and Secondary Education), Santosh Lad (Labour and Employment), and S S Mallikarjun (Mines and Geology and Horticulture).

Other ministers who continue with their existing portfolios include deputy chief minister G Parameshwara (Revenue and Sports), Priyank Kharge (Home, Information Technology and Biotechnology, and e-Governance), K J George (Energy and Tourism), M B Patil (Large and Medium Industries and Infrastructure Development), Satish Jarkiholi (Public Works), Krishna Byre Gowda (Greater Bengaluru Development), Eshwari Kulkarni (Development and Panchayati Raj), Yathindra Siddaramaiah (Urban Development), Byrathi Suresh (Transport) and Sharan Prakash Patil (Media, Education and Skill Development).

The newly inducted ministers have been assigned portfolios including Agriculture to Narendra Swamy, Food, Civil Supplies and Consumer Affairs to Rizwan Arshad, Municipal Administration to H C Balakrishna, Excise and Taxation to Shrikanth K M, Skill Development, Minor Irrigation and Science and Technology to Dr Jagu Singh, ST Welfare to R Jaghu

murthy, Muzrai, Fisheries, Ports and Inland Water Transport to K S Basavanthappa, Small Scale Industries and Public Enterprises to Vijayanand Kashappa, and Sugar and Textiles to Rudrapa Lamani.

Laxman Savadi has been assigned Cooperation, Basavaraj Raya Reddy Higher Education and C S Puttaranga Shetty Animal Husbandry and Sericulture.

The allocation comes amid dissatisfaction within the Congress, with several legislators who were seeking ministerial berths expressing displeasure after being left out. The absence of a woman minister is also expected to add to pressure on Shivakumar to fill the remaining berth with a woman.

The government also appointed Congress MLA A S Ponnanna as political secretary to Shivakumar with Cabinet Minister status.

"A S Ponnanna, Member of the Legislative Assembly from the Virajpet Assembly Constituency, is hereby appointed as the Political Secretary to the chief minister with immediate effect and until further orders, and is accorded the status of a Cabinet Minister," the notification said.

Ponnanna had been seeking a ministerial position and had expressed displeasure after being excluded from the cabinet expansion.

Demand for Nagendra's resignation, Cauvery to dominate House: Oppn

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BENGALURU: Opposition leaders on Wednesday said that their ongoing demand for state planning and statistics minister B Nagendra's resignation over corruption allegations would play a major role as part of their strategy for the state legislature's monsoon session, which is scheduled to begin on Thursday.

Nagendra's re-induction will feature as a key issue alongside the ongoing dispute with Tamil Nadu over the sharing of Cauvery water, they said.

Addressing a press conference on Tuesday, state BJP chief BY Vijayendra said, "We are warning the CM today that Nagendra's resignation must be obtained before the House begins. Otherwise, both outside and inside the House, the BJP and JDS will fight this issue until the CM obtains Nagendra's resignation."

"Was there any fear? Or did pressure come from the Congress high command on the CM? That also needs to be clarified," he added.

Ministers express confidence of delivery
Meanwhile, after the state government announced portfolio allocations on Wednesday, ministers expressed confidence about their responsibilities and thanked the government.

State agriculture minister Narendra Swamy said his background from an agricultural family would give his approach to the department. "I am also a son of a farmer," he told news agency ANI.

Higher education minister Basavaraj Rayareddi said he was comfortable with the responsibility, having led the department earlier.

School education Madhu Bangarappa expressed gratefulness. "I was wishing that I continue in the last three years, reforms were made that were endorsed by the opposition party also. I'm very honoured that they have endorsed me to continue in one of the biggest portfolios,"

(with agency inputs)

bangalore talkies

What our histories owe to the food that we eat



Shoba Narayan

Given that we celebrate Independence Day in August, it becomes fashionable to vilify the British. However, even the most ardent nationalist in this state will doff their Mysore peta to Benjamin Lewis Rice, the administrator-antiquarian/historian in whose memory stands a church on Avenue Road in the heart of Bengaluru, the city where he was born all the way back in 1837.

Rice was educated in England, and held many posts in the Kingdom of Mysore. It was a land he loved and wrote about.

Consider this paragraph in his monumental 1897 Mysore Gazetteer: "If there be any truth in the observation that small countries with diversified and distinctive physical characteristics have played the greatest part in the world's history, and given rise to its most distinguished men, Greece, Palestine, England and others being cited as instances, Mysore, it seems to me, may fairly claim a place in the category. She is the peculiar home of the sandal and also of tea, a special haunt of the elephant, rears a famous and superior breed of horned cattle, supplies as the staple food of her people the nutrient grain of ragi, was the cradle in India and is still the chief garden for coffee cultivation. Thus in every department of the natural world she may claim some pre-eminence."

Rice's records detail a sudden, massive agricultural fluctuation in the ragi-growing belt of Southern Karnataka (including Bengaluru and its environs) between 1871 and 1873. It was an abrupt relinquishment of wet rice cultivation in favour of ragi and oleseeds. This wasn't a culinary whim, but an administrative side effect. The control of irrigation channels and tanks was transferred from local Revenue officers to the Public Works Department to enforce repairs and curb water waste. When the new Revenue Survey rendered all occupied lands liable for tax whether they were actively cultivated or not, the area under wet rice dropped drastically from 1.32 million acres to

just half a million. The fields reverted to dry-land ragi, a crop managed with staggering precision, and more importantly, less dependent on water. As the historical chronicler Mark Wilks famously noted, "The whole world does not, perhaps, exhibit a cleaner system of husbandry than that of the cultivation of ragi in the home fields of Mysore."

Both Rice and Wilks chronicled agriculture. However, if you want to look at the historical zenith of regional gastronomy, you must open the ancient Sanskrit and Kannada shastras. In the 12th-century text *Manusollasa*, written by the Kalyani Chalukya King Someshvara III, the only sweet dessert worthy of mention is the *payasam*. The text includes topics on poetry, art, music, dance and all good things including perfumes and food. In his royal kitchen, cooking was done exclusively with pure ghee, tamarind provided the sourness, and chilies had not yet arrived to disrupt the palate. The king was clearly an aesthete, as he gave specific instructions about food preparation, including a technique that my grandmother and aunts still use: soaking hingi or asafoetida in water.

The second chapter describes the preparation of 35 breads, sweets and snacks. The second chapter describes the preparation of various soft drinks, salty, sour and sweet in taste. The third chapter is on nine types of sweet payasam (pudding), eight types of cooled rice, and 24 types of mixed rice dishes. The remaining three chapters are on dishes made with various vegetables. These include recipes for 28 dishes with eggplant, 16 dishes with jackfruit, 25 dishes made with raw bananas and banana flowers. The last chapter contains recipes using bamboo shoots and myrobalan, along with preservation methods for pickles and papads.

All of this reminds us that before we became obsessive modern dieters, the traditional idea of a good meal was beautifully unadorned. As an epologist MN Srinivas observed in *The Remembered Village*, a satisfying meal meant eating until the stomach could hold no more, punctuated by a necessary, resounding post-meal belch, which gratified the hostess and signalled satisfaction.

(Shoba Narayan is Bengaluru-based award-winning author. She is also a freelance contributor who writes about art, food, fashion and travel for a number of publications.)

COURT ORDERS PRELIMINARY PROBE

Land dealings of Kharges' trust under scanner

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BENGALURU: A special court handling cases involving elected representatives has ordered a preliminary inquiry into a complaint alleging irregularities in the Siddhartha Vilhar Trust's property and financial dealings. The court listed Congress national president Mallikarjun Kharge, his son and state home minister Priyank Kharge as respondents among other prominent names.

The order was passed on Tuesday. The court examined the complaints and attached documents, submitted by Lankhamukta Karnataka Nirman Vaidiki state secretary Vijayavahara Marathe on behalf of the organisation. It scheduled the recording of the petitioner's statement on August 28.

The trust is closely associated with Kharge family and had by the AICC chief's second son Rahul M Kharge.

The complaint alleges illegal allotment of an industrial plot to the trust, in addition to other irregularities.

It sought an investigation by the Lokayukta police under Section 175(3) of the Bharatiya Nagar Palika Sahita, which also alleged offences under Sections 314, 316, 336 and 61 of the Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita as well as provisions of the Prevention of Corruption Act.

To be sure, the order does not call for a police investigation. The court said the procedure prescribed under the BNS must be followed first before such an order can be considered.

The court also listed Kharge's wife Radhabai, his son Rahul M Kharge, state heavy industries minister M B Patil and officials of the Karnataka Industrial Areas Development Board as respondents.



Mallikarjun Kharge

plaint did not fully satisfy Section 333(2) of the BNS, which requires a complaint to be based on facts which are proved by documents or other evidence. The complainant had instead stated that the allegations were true "to the best of my knowledge and belief", without specifying identifying the two categories required under the provision.

The complainant's counsel, senior advocate Lakshmi Ayyangar, said that the complainant had stated that the allegations were true "to the best of my knowledge and belief", without specifying identifying the two categories required under the provision.

The court examined the relationship between Sections 175(3) and 175(4), observing that they must be read together and that public servants receive what it described as a "two-tier protection" during the investigation and cognizance stages.

It also referred to Supreme Court precedents, including the landmark Om Prakash Ambadkar vs State of Maharashtra, while considering the safeguards provided under the BNS.

Expired ingredients found in food safety raid at health dept's canteen

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BENGALURU: As part of the ongoing drive against food safety violations in Bengaluru's hotels and eateries, a Wednesday raid on a canteen run by the state health department and found allegedly expired ingredients, officials said.

At the Arogya Soudha canteen inside the headquarters of the state health department on Magadi Road, Food Safety and Drug Administration officials found the premises unhygienic and discovered expired idli rava and coconut powder. The inspection's findings stated that food storage practices fell short of FSSAI requirements, and pest control had also not been carried out.

Earlier on Tuesday, officials inspected Zomato's Hyperpure facility at Sakalavara Nagar and found problems involving several products despite the premises itself being described as clean. The official report stated:

OFFICIALS ALSO FOUND DIRTY PREMISES AND LACK OF PEST CONTROL AT THE AROGYA SOUDHA CANTEN ON MAGADI ROAD

"The premises was kept clean and tidy."

Officials found 146 kg of chicken without the manufacturer's FSSAI licence number and 40 kg of garlic for which the manufacturer's FSSAI licence was not in force. They also recorded 300 kg of rice, 20 kg of dry fruits and 15 kg of masala. The team collected 40 samples from the warehouse, comprising five legal samples and 35 survey samples.

The Food Safety and Drug Administration subsequently issued a notice to the Zomato Hyperpure unit and said further legal action would follow under

the prescribed provisions. Zomato did not respond to HT's queries for a comment on the findings till the time of going to print.

Govt bans sale of gutka, pan masala for 1 year
Meanwhile, the state government has barred the manufacture, storage, transportation, distribution and sale of gutka, pan masala and other food products containing tobacco or nicotine for one year.

The order, issued by the Commissioner of Food Safety on August 10, also covers products marketed under other names when tobacco or nicotine remains part of the final product. To be sure, the measure does not prohibit people from consuming tobacco or nicotine products.

The Food Safety Division of the Department of Food Safety and Drugs Administration directed officials to conduct regular inspections to ensure that the order was enforced.

I-Day preparations underway



Workers engaged in preparations for the Freedom Ibbah event, scheduled near Vidhana Soudha as part of upcoming Independence Day celebrations, in Bengaluru on Wednesday.

K'TAKA, ISRAEL HOLD TALKS FOR CYBERSECURITY COOPERATION

Press Trust of India

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BENGALURU: The Karnataka government and the Consulate General of Israel in Bengaluru on Wednesday held an event to strengthen cooperation in cybersecurity, talent development, research, technology and digital resilience, officials said.

The dialogue, held under the theme "Stronger Together, Secure Tomorrow", was organised as part of Karnataka's ongoing international technology partnerships under its Global Innovation Alliance.

According to a statement, a delegation of 10 Israeli cybersecurity companies participated in the programme, which featured technology demonstrations and B2B meetings.

Streaming apps found on Prajwal's phone in jail

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BENGALURU: Netflix, Instagram, WhatsApp and Prime Video were among applications found on a mobile phone seized from former MP Prajwal Revanna during a Central Crime Branch raid at Parappana Agrahara Central Prison, where he is serving a life sentence.

The applications were installed on a light blue Redmi 5G handset recovered from Room 4 on the first floor of Security Section 3 during a search conducted between 2 pm and 9 pm on Tuesday. The apps were password protected, and both Revanna and fellow inmate Pratap Rai told the search team that they did not know the passwords, the FIR registered over the matter said.

The phone was accompanied by a white charger, a blue pocket notebook and a black SanDisk pen drive. The raid was conducted by Revanna and Rai, an uncaptured prisoner.

While the phone was recovered from Revanna, officials said Rai told them that the phone, charger and pen drive belonged to him and that he used the handset to speak to his relatives and lawyer. Revanna also told the team that he had used Rai's phone to call his relatives and lawyer. He claimed the notebook belonged to him.

The CB seized all four items and lodged a complaint against the two inmates under provisions of the Karnataka Prisons (Amendment) Act, 2022, and the Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita. The complaint alleges that prohibited articles were brought into the prison without authorisation and used by the inmates.

DGP Prison and Correctional Services Alok Kumar said the raid covered high profile prisoners and lasted about four to five hours. He said another mobile phone was found in Rai's possession. "Yesterday (Tuesday) afternoon, a raid was conducted by CB on all the high profile prisoners. An Android phone has been seized from Prajwal Revanna's possession," Kumar said.

Police are examining CCTV footage and collecting further information before issuing notices and taking additional action.



Prajwal Revanna

"A detailed enquiry is being conducted on this incident," Kumar said.

Kumar said the Assistant Superintendent concerned had been suspended following a report against prison officials, while a show cause notice was issued to the superintendent of Bengaluru Central Prison. "CB has lodged the complaint with Parappana Agrahara Police Station, and registration of an FIR is in progress," Kumar said.

The seizure has also led to a report against prison officials. Assistant Superintendent Irrappa Rangapur was suspended for alleged dereliction of duty, while the superintendent of Bengaluru Central Prison was served a show cause notice.

Home minister Priyank Kharge said he had visited Parappana Agrahara Central Prison two to three days earlier and noticed lapses during

his inspection. He said he discussed them with regional officials before obtaining chief minister D K Shivakumar's permission for the raid.

He said similar searches would be conducted across the state. "Whether it is Kalaburagi, Belagavi, Bengaluru or any other prison, we will take strict action. We will keep doing this," said the minister.

He said officials continuing to follow "old practices" would be identified and face legal action. If any official was found involved in criminal activity, the government would consider dismissal from service.

Revanna, 36, represented Hassan in the Lok Sabha from 2019 to 2023. He was convicted in August 2023 by the Special Court for People's Representatives for raping a domestic worker at a farm house in Holenarasipura, Hassan district.

Delimitation row: TN House adopts resolution to freeze LS seats at 543

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CHENNAI: The Tamil Nadu assembly on Wednesday passed a resolution urging the Union government to freeze the number of Lok Sabha seats at 543 and ensure 33% women's reservation in legislative bodies on the basis of this.

The move that comes amidst efforts by the government to mobilise the required numbers in Parliament to legislate the constitution amendment bill that seeks to fast track the reservation, already cleared by both Houses of Parliament, by delimiting it from the ongoing national census and subsequent delimitation, and instead prescribe an alternative mechanism for delimitation.

The Tamilaga Vettai Kazhagam (TVK) government led by chief minister C Joseph Vijay was supported by the main opposition party in the state assembly, Dravida Munnetra Kazhagam (DMK), and its own allies such as the Left parties and Vaiduthalai Chiruthaigal Katchi (VCK).

The Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP), All India Anna Dravida Munnetra Kazhagam (AIADMK), Pattali Makkal Katchi (PMK), the late actor-politician Vijayanthi founded Desiya Murpokku Dravida Kazhagam (DMDK) opposed the resolution.

In April 2026, the Union government introduced The Constitutional (131st Amendment) Bill, 2026, in Parliament to

renumber the 50 year freeze on delimitation and take up delimitation exercise based on the



Tamil Nadu CM Vijay speaks during the state assembly session in Chennai on Wednesday.

2011 census and increase the number of Lok Sabha members from 550 to 850 but failed to garner the numbers required to pass this.

In these circumstances, the chief minister said, based on the knowledge that the aforementioned constitutional amendment bill would be brought forward again, it is a stark reality that if delimitation is conducted based on any census after 1971, the parliamentary representation of southern states including Tamil Nadu which have successfully controlled population growth would be permanently affected.

The main reason for this was a lack of clarity about how the delimitation exercise would be carried out while the government said that each state would see its Lok Sabha seats increase by 50%, the bill itself was silent

on this. To be sure, if the government were to change the bill to incorporate this, some of the opposition to delimitation could vanish.

Vijay said if the aforementioned constitutional amendment bill is brought again, the parliamentary representation of southern states including Tamil Nadu which have successfully controlled population growth would be permanently affected.

"We request all honourable members of this assembly, across all party lines, to pass this resolution unanimously," he said.

Leader of Opposition and DMK leader Udhayanidhi Stalin said the firm stance of the DMK was that under no circumstances should Tamil Nadu be affected in the name of the

delimitation. Udhayanidhi said, "The critical issue here is this — the freeze on the delimitation exercise from 1971 to 2026 must be extended for another 25 years."

Responding to the resolution, AIADMK general secretary Edappadi K Palaniswami said, "There is nothing wrong with redrawing the boundaries of the Lok Sabha and legislative assembly constituencies for administrative convenience."

"AIADMK rejects the resolution regarding delimitation brought forward by the TVK government for political reasons. We support only the resolution concerning the reservation for women," he said.

BJP's lone legislator Bhogaraju (Nilgiris) had questioned the TVK government on why the resolution was being taken on such a "hurried manner". In his remarks, Bhogaraju said, "Honorable Speaker Sir, I do not understand why so much hurry in this (for passing a resolution)."

He said, "The delimitation bill is still only in a preliminary draft stage and under consideration."

"The BJP does not accept bringing such a resolution in haste. We oppose this resolution," he said.

On increasing the women's reservation, the legislator said, "The world knows that the BJP is a party that gives a lot of importance to women. It is a party that always believes in prioritising women. Therefore, we have no second opinion that 33 per cent reservation must be given to women. We fully accept and welcome that initiative."

TVK leader pitches for PM from Tamil Nadu

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CHENNAI: TVK leader and public works minister Aadhar Arjuna on Wednesday batted for a Prime Minister from Tamil Nadu, and alleging a north-south divide, he said, political power is not the exclusive preserve of northern states such as Uttar Pradesh.

Taking part in the discussion in the State Assembly on the anti-delimitation resolution moved by chief minister C Joseph Vijay, the minister traced the socio-political history of Tamil Nadu — to secure social justice — from the days of reformist leader Periyar E V Ramasamy and iconic leader C N Annadurai.

Hailing CM Vijay's resolution as "historic", Arjuna said its basis is founded on the principle that there is no union government without a strong state government. He said that Dravidian stalwart Anna had asserted in Parliament that India cannot be built without state autonomy and that the nation's progress is not possible by avoiding the progress of the states.

In this context, Arjuna alleged that, similar to the US President Abraham Lincoln, he said, adding that Anna's principles were being followed by the TVK.

Such ideals of the late iconic leader were the bedrock of Tamil Nadu and India and not only for the DMK party.



Aadhar Arjuna

and it was the North-South War. Like that, today, be it India and we are faced with the north-south war. The Constitution authored by revolutionary Dr BR Ambedkar emphasises equality, and there is Article 14: everyone is equal," he said.

Furthermore, Arjuna said political power for the sake of everyone must be created, and state autonomy is a very important aspect in such a framework.

Accordingly, he said Tamil Nadu, which is home to social justice-based reservation, was instrumental in the first Constitutional amendment as Periyar E V and Anna came together.

"This is Tamil Nadu's history and our chief minister is following that path, this resolution is to protect the Constitution," he said, adding that Anna's principles were being followed by the TVK.

Such ideals of the late iconic leader were the bedrock of Tamil Nadu and India and not only for the DMK party.

AMENDMENT TO MINING LAWS NOT NECESSARY: PMK

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CHENNAI: PMK President Anbumaram Ramadoss on Wednesday urged the Centre to immediately withdraw the proposed amendment to the Mines and Minerals Development and Regulation Act, warning that it usurps the taxation rights of state governments and threatens Tamil Nadu with an annual revenue loss of Rs 1,000 crore.

In a statement, the PMK leader alleged that the introduction of Section 9D in the mines and minerals development and regulation (MMDR) amendment bill, recently tabled in the Lok Sabha, is a direct blow to state autonomy.

The proposed clause strips the state governments from independently imposing taxes, cesses, or surcharges on mineral resources," he said, adding, "moreover, it waives pending tax dues owed by mining contractors under previous state levies once the amendment takes effect."

"Even though land and mineral resources fall under the State List, the Centre is 'misusing' its power to regulate taxation, effectively stripping state governments of their revenue-generating capacity," the PMK leader alleged.

The YSRCP chief asked the party MLAs to raise the issue of irregularities in Mega DSSC 2025 teachers' recruitment. "We took up 10 different issues through the party on the issue in the last 74 days, placing all the evidence to establish a viewpoint. We exposed irregularities, including leakage of question papers, outsourcing scandal and irregularities in sports quota appointments, and demanded a CBI inquiry into the role of education minister," he said.

Jagan also asked the MLAs to

STIR AGAINST VIZHINJAM SEAPORT

FCR sets aside FCR renewal denial to NGOs

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KOCHI: The Kerala High Court has set aside the Centre's decision not to renew the FCR certificate of two NGOs, accused of central agencies of funding agitation against the Vizhinjam sea port, saying that financial support to a protest cannot be seen as diversion of foreign funds. The High Court said that the right to protest is guaranteed under the Constitution and therefore, financial support to protesters cannot be seen as a diversion of foreign funds for an undesirable purpose.

"When the right to protest is constitutionally guaranteed, exercise of such rights cannot be labelled as an 'undesirable purpose' or against public interest. The term 'undesirable purpose' in section 12(4)(a)(ii) of the FCR cannot be interpreted to mean undesirable to the Government or undesirable to the political will. A peaceful protest against a project by persons who have a grievance or who apprehend injury to them, cannot be viewed as against public interest."

The court also said that "executive or administrative disapproval" for protests or dissents cannot convert the exercise of a constitutionally protected right into an undesirable purpose or as against public interest.

"Thus, even if it is assumed that some financial support was provided to the protesters, it cannot be treated as diversion of foreign contribution for an undesirable purpose or against public interest, tantamounting to violation of any provision in the FCR," it said.

It further said that characterisation of a purpose as 'undesirable' has to be rooted in a legal prohibition or a public injury. The court also noted that there was no financial trail between the petitioner NGOs — Kerala Social Service Forum and Save a Family Plan India — and any of the protesters directly.

"Thus, the action of the respondents in denying the renewal is illegal and liable to be interfered with. Irrelevant considerations have been made the

THE HC SAID THAT RIGHT TO PROTEST IS GUARANTEED UNDER THE CONSTITUTION AND FINANCIAL AID TO PROTESTERS CANNOT BE SEEN AS A DIVERSION OF FOREIGN FUNDS

basis for rejecting renewal of FCR status after ignoring the relevant considerations," the court said.

It further said that the intelligence report states that the Latin Catholic Archdiocese of Trivandrum (LCAT), representing the agitating fisherfolk community in Vizhinjam, had out the agitation and that out of the 29 NGOs involved in the agitation, nine were FCR registered with 5 of them having active FCR status.

The court said that the two NGOs names were not part of either the five active FCR status organisations or even in the list of the 29 NGOs who have participated in the agitation.

"It is a travesty of justice that despite not being part of any protest, the petitioners' application for renewal of the FCR certificate has been rejected," it said.

The court said that in the instant matter, no serious violation or misuse of foreign contribution received by the NGOs was evident or borne out by the records and the authorities ought to have visited the application for renewal.

"Thus, the refusal to renew the certificate of the petitioners under FCR is arbitrary and illegal. The petitioners are entitled to have their certificates renewed. Hence, the orders refusing to renew the certificate of registration of the petitioners under FCR are set aside and the competent amongst the respondents, including the Union home ministry, is directed to issue the certificate on the basis of the observations made above, in a time-bound manner, at any rate within three months from the date of receipt of this judgment."

The court also noted that there was no financial trail between the petitioner NGOs — Kerala Social Service Forum and Save a Family Plan India — and any of the protesters directly.

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Police constable found dead in ACP office, kin suspect foul play

Srinivasa Rao Apparasu
letters@hindustantimes.com

HYDERABAD: A 26-year-old police constable was found dead in the restroom of a police station at the LB Nagar in Hyderabad in the early hours of Wednesday. The police said, adding that prima facie, it appeared to be a death by suicide, even as his family members suspected foul play.

The body of the constable was found in the rest room of the LB Nagar assistant commissioner of police (ACP) office at around 2.30 am. The constable had been attached to the office for e-COPS duty and was working on night shifts.

In the other police personnel who noticed him immediately shifted him to nearby Kamini Hospital, where doctors declared him dead on arrival," a police official said. The body of the LB Nagar police station.

The official said the deceased hailed from Ranga Reddy district and had been staying in a room with his friends at Karmanghat, about a kilometre away from the police station.

"He was a quiet person and there were no indications of the

THE CONSTABLE'S FATHER CLAIMED THERE WERE BLOODSTAINS IN THE REST ROOM WHERE HE WAS FOUND, AND HIS MOTHER ALLEGED THAT HE WAS TORTURED

deceased experiencing any kind of stress. Indices also revealed that he did not have any family-related problems. He attended the duty on Tuesday as well without any complaints," the police official said.

His body was subsequently shifted to Osmania General Hospital for post-mortem examination and a case of suspicious death was registered at the LB Nagar police station.

After receiving information about the incident, senior police officials reached the station and enquired into the circumstances surrounding the constable's death.

Police informed the family members of the deceased, who

rushed to the police station on Wednesday morning.

Tension prevailed outside the LB Nagar police station with the family members and their villagers staging a protest. At one point, some protesters allegedly entered the police station and damaged a computer and a printer. As the situation turned tense, a large number of police personnel were deployed at the station to bring the situation under control.

LB Nagar deputy commissioner of police Anuraadh inspected the police station and made inquiries about the possible cause of the constable's death.

Speaking to reporters, the deceased constable's father refused to believe that his son had died by suicide. "There were bloodstains in the rest room where he was found dead. We want an explanation from the police on what exactly led to the death of my son," he demanded. His mother alleged that his son might have been tortured. Ibrahimpattam MLA, Malreddy Ranga Reddy, who represents the constituency, reached the police station and spoke to the bereaved family.

6 dead after speeding truck rams 3-wheeler

Srinivasa Rao Apparasu
letters@hindustantimes.com

HYDERABAD: Six people were killed and six others were critically injured after a speeding tanker truck ramed into an auto-rickshaw in Sangareddy district, police said on Wednesday.

The incident occurred near Satwar village in Zaheerabad mandal where an auto-rickshaw carrying 11 women agricultural labourers, was taking a U-turn on the Hyderabad-Mumbai national highway (NH-65) around 8.30 pm on Tuesday, police said.

An officer from Zaheerabad police station said the agricultural labourers from Sangareddy in Bidar district of Karnataka had come to the Budhera area of Municipality mandal in Sangareddy district to work in agricultural fields, mainly for weeding operations."

After completing their work, they were returning in an auto-rickshaw. When the auto-rickshaw was making a U-turn on the highway near Satwar, a heavy tanker travelling at high speed from Mumbai towards Hyderabad crashed into it, the police

officer told reporters.

The impact of the collision was so severe that the auto-rickshaw was badly mangled. "Four people died on the spot, while two others succumbed to their injuries while undergoing treatment," police said.

The deceased were identified as Rekhamma (36), Kavitha (40), Srividya (45), Reshma (28), Nikhita (30) and auto-rickshaw driver Devadas (35). Devadas and Nikhita were a married couple.

Six other people travelling in the auto-rickshaw suffered serious injuries and were shifted to the government hospital at Zaheerabad for treatment. The condition of two of them is said to be critical, police said.

"We have registered a case of accident and taken up an investigation into the accident," the officer said. A statement from the CMO said chief minister A Revathi instructed the district authorities to extend all possible help to the families of the deceased and ensure that the injured get the best possible treatment. In this incident, a separate accident took place on the same highway, in which two people were killed when a car crashed into a divider.

No tolerance towards digital offences: Naidu

Srinivasa Rao Apparasu
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HYDERABAD: Andhra Pradesh Chief Minister N Chandrababu Naidu on Wednesday directed the police to adopt a zero-tolerance approach towards political crimes, digital offences, obscene social media posts and crimes against women, while calling for stricter and more effective police to deal with the changing nature of crime.

Addressing a video conference with nearly 1,650 police officers, ranging from the Director General of Police (DGP) to Station House Officers (SHOs) across the state, Naidu said political affiliations should not be allowed to shield criminals or encourage anti-social activities.

He specifically questioned the motorcycle stunts reportedly performed on public roads during a political party rally at Ibrahimpatnam and said no political party should be permitted to conduct such activities at the cost of public safety.

He also pointed to instances in which police personnel had allegedly come under attack.



N Chandrababu Naidu

The chief minister said political parties had a responsibility to ensure that their programmes and policies were accessible to the public. While condolence visits or meeting affected families were legitimate activities, he said, demonstrations that block public roads for prolonged periods could cause serious hardship to citizens.

Citing an incident in Visakhapatnam in which roads were reportedly blocked for nearly three hours, Naidu said such disruptions could create difficulties for ambulances transporting patients to hospitals as well as people travelling to work.

He warned the police that even a minor lapse in maintaining law and order could have consequences for the entire police system.

Bid to cause rift in NDA: TDP, allies claim on YSRCP social media drive

Srinivasa Rao Apparasu
letters@hindustantimes.com

HYDERABAD: The Telugu Desam Party, Janasena Party and Bharatiya Janata Party, constituents of the ruling coalition government in Andhra Pradesh, on Wednesday cautioned their members against the YSRCP Congress party's alleged attempt to sow discord among the cadres of alliance partners through fake social media posts.

In a joint statement issued under the name of the NDA social media coordination committee, the three parties cautioned their leaders, workers and supporters against being misled by the YSRCP.

They also asked them not to indulge in infighting provoked by YSRCP statements posted on social media. The NDA social media coordination committee alleged that the YSRCP was operating fake accounts by posing as supporters of one alliance party or another and using them to provoke clashes among the TDP, Jana Sena and BJP cadres according to the committee.

YSRCP sympathisers were allegedly pretending to be supporters of one alliance partner while launching personal attacks and making derogatory remarks against leaders of another constituent party.

THE NDA SOCIAL MEDIA PANEL ALLEGED THAT THE YSRCP WAS OPERATING FAKE ACCOUNTS BY POSING AS SUPPORTERS OF THE PARTIES

They were also allegedly posting comments and content intended to damage the reputation of alliance leaders. "For instance, a fake account posing as a TDP supporter praises TDP president and chief minister N Chandrababu Naidu while criticising Jana Sena chief and deputy chief minister Pawan Kalyan. Similarly, another fake account posing as a Jana Sena supporter launches severe criticism against Chandrababu Naidu," the committee

said. It observed that genuine alliance workers, unable to identify the alleged YSRCP strategy, were becoming emotional and reacting aggressively against leaders and supporters of their own coalition partners. This, in turn, was leading to disputes within the alliance and indirectly benefiting the YSRCP politically, it said.

The committee stressed that the three NDA partners should work together to counter the alleged YSRCP campaign and highlight the development and welfare programmes being implemented by the coalition government.

The committee issued a strong warning that social media activists belonging to the TDP, Jana Sena or BJP would face strict action if they engaged in personal attacks, abusive comments or vindictive campaigns against leaders of alliance partners or their family members.

It clarified that the primary objective was to identify "pseudo" supporters and prevent their alleged attempts to create discord within the alliance.

YSRCP's assembly boycott to continue in monsoon session

Srinivasa Rao Apparasu
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HYDERABAD: Opposition YSR Congress Party on Wednesday decided to continue its boycott of the Andhra Pradesh Legislative Assembly during the monsoon session, while raising issues linked to public interest and highlighting the failure of the Telugu Desam Party-led coalition government.

Addressing the party MLAs at the office of A Tade-palli, YSRCP president and former chief minister Y S Jagan Mohan Reddy reiterated that there was no point in attending the assembly session as speaker Chintalapudi Anjan Kumar was unwilling to give the status of leader of opposition to the party. "The government is against recognising the YSRCP as the leader of opposition only to gag its voice. I shall continue to highlight the public issues through regular media conferences to show people the other side of the coin," he said.

The YSRCP chief, however,



Y S Jagan Mohan Reddy

said since the party had enough strength in the legislative council, it would act as the voice of the people and highlight public issues," Jagan said.

The YSRCP chief asked the party MLAs to raise the issue of irregularities in Mega DSSC 2025 teachers' recruitment. "We took up 10 different issues through the party on the issue in the last 74 days, placing all the evidence to establish a viewpoint. We exposed irregularities, including leakage of question papers, outsourcing scandal and irregularities in sports quota appointments, and demanded a CBI inquiry into the role of education minister," he said.

Jagan also asked the MLAs to

raise issues like failures in the implementation of fees reimbursement.

No attendance, no salary for MLAs: Speaker Meanwhile, state assembly speaker Chintalapudi Anjan Kumar Patrauda expressed dissatisfaction over the decision of the YSRCP MLAs to boycott the state assembly proceedings.

Speaking to reporters, the speaker questioned why salaries should be paid to YSRCP MLAs who decided not to attend sessions. "Legislators are elected to discuss public issues and raise the concerns of their constituencies in the assembly. What is the rationale behind their continued absence from the House?" he asked. Aayanna Patrauda suggested that the matter should be discussed in Parliament and that the state legislation should be enacted to deal with legislators who remain absent from the House. He said a face-recognition system had been introduced in the Assembly to prevent proxy attendance.

MY INDIA

Clear minerals bill

Jaiveer Gandhi

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NEW DELHI: The Lok Sabha on Wednesday passed the Mines and Minerals (Development and Regulation) Amendment Bill, 2026, which aims to restrict state governments from imposing taxes, cesses or levies on minerals rights and 'minor-bearing lands', via a voice vote sans debate amid opposition protests.



The bill aims to restrict state governments from imposing taxes, cesses or levies on mineral rights.

The bill, which amends the Mines and Minerals (Development and Regulation) Act, 1957, was introduced on Monday by Union Minister for Coal and Mines G. Kishan Reddy. It was passed in the second half of the Lok Sabha session on Wednesday, with Jagdamba Pal, who was in the chair, beginning proceedings by asking the Opposition to maintain decorum.

The amendment bill introduces a new section that says that "no tax, cess or such other levy (by whatever name called) shall be imposed by the state government on mineral rights; or mineral bearing lands, either based on mineral quantity or mineral value or royalty payable, except in accordance with such conditions or restrictions as may be prescribed by the Central Government."

having ore content in accordance with the parameters prescribed under the MMDR Act. The proposed amendments are the failure of a July 2024 ruling by the Supreme Court that upheld the power of states to levy taxes on mineral rights and mineral-bearing lands.

The bill clarifies any tax, cess or other levy which is not deposited with the state government or recovered by it before the commencement of the Mines and Minerals (Development and Regulation) Amendment Act, 2026, will be deemed to be invalid at all material times. However, those already deposited, will not be liable to be refunded.

PARL OKAYS BILL TO RENAME KERALA

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NEW DELHI: Parliament on Wednesday passed a bill to rename Kerala as Keralam, with the Rajya Sabha clearing the legislation with a voice vote. The Lok Sabha passed the Kerala (Alteration of Name) Bill, 2026, on Tuesday.

"The bill provides that the State of Kerala will be known as the State of Keralam, and hence there is a proposal to rename the State of Kerala to Keralam," minister of state for home affairs Nityanand Rai said. Amendments will be made in the First Schedule to the Constitution by modifying the name of Kerala as Keralam in accordance with Article 3 of the Constitution.

NCDC BILL PASSED IN UPPER HOUSE AMID OPPN STIR

NEW DELHI: The Rajya Sabha passed the National Co-operative Development Corporation (Amendment) Bill, 2026, by voice vote on Wednesday, a day after the Lok Sabha approved it. Opposition parties staged a walkout before the House took up the bill for voting.

The bill amends the National Co-operative Development Corporation Act, 1962, to broaden the Corporation's mandate and enable it to extend loans and grants directly not only to co-operative societies but also to other organisations engaged in co-operative development, provided the funds are ultimately used for the benefit of co-operatives.

"It is proposed to enable the corporation to provide loans and grants directly to the cooperative societies or any entity engaged in cooperative development for the benefit of co-operatives, subject to furnishing security as may be required by the corporation," the statement of objects and reasons of the bill said.

Replying to the debate on the bill, minister of state for co-operation Murlidhar Mohol said, "The bill seeks to broaden the provision for additional budgetary financial assistance by the government."

TN passes resolution against delimitation

Malikarjun Kharge

CONG ALLEGES BJP DID PURIFICATION RITUAL ON STAGE USED BY KHARGE

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DEHRADUN: Uttarakhand's Congress unit on Wednesday alleged that people linked to the ruling Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) carried out a purification ritual on the stage used by party chief Mallikarjun Kharge during his recent rally in Haldwani. The BJP, however, dismissed the allegation. Kharge had attended the rally on August 8 at Haldwani's Ramleela Maidan.

The State Congress chief Ganesh Godiyal alleged that a purification ritual was carried out on the stage after the rally. He urged the Naitinal senior superintendent of police to take cognisance of the matter and conduct an impartial probe. "There is no place for discrimination and untouchability in modern democratic India. We strongly oppose such a mindset towards any community, but traditional means," Godiyal said.

The ruling BJP termed the allegations an attempt to insult Sanatan Dharma and divide society on caste lines. State minister Khajana Das claimed his party has no connection with Shri Ram Sena Dhamarth Seva Samiti, which conducted the ritual.

S Vijay Karthik
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CHENNAI: The Tamil Nadu assembly on Wednesday passed a resolution urging the Union government to freeze the number of Lok Sabha seats at 543 and ensure 33% women's reservation in legislative bodies on the basis of this.



Tamil Nadu CM S. Vijay Karthik speaks during the state assembly session in Chennai on Wednesday.

The move that comes amid efforts by the government to mobilise the required numbers in Parliament to legislate the constitution amendment bill that seeks to fast track the reservation, already cleared by the Union government by delimiting it from the ongoing national census and subsequent delimitation, and instead prescribe an alternative mechanism for delimitation.

The TVK government led by chief minister C. Joseph Vijay was supported by the main opposition party in the state, the DMK, and its own allies such as the Left parties and VCK. The BJP, AIADMK, PMK, and DMKD opposed the resolution.

of clarity about how the delimitation exercise would be carried out, while the government said that each state would see its Lok Sabha seats increased by 50%, the bill itself was silent on this.

To be sure, if the government were to change the bill to incorporate this, some of the opposition to delimitation could vanish.

"Vijay said if the aforementioned constitutional amendment bill is brought again, the parliamentary representation of southern states including Tamil Nadu which have successfully controlled population growth would be permanently affected."

"We request all honourable members of this assembly across all party lines, to pass this resolution unanimously," he said.

Leader of Opposition and DMK leader Udhayanidhi Stalin said the firm stance of the DMK was that under no circumstances

should Tamil Nadu be affected in the name of the delimitation. "The critical issue here is this — the freeze on the delimitation exercise from 1971 to 2026 must be extended for another 25 years," he said.

Responding to the resolution, AIADMK general secretary Edappadi K. Palaniswami said, "There is nothing wrong with redrawing the boundaries of the Lok Sabha and legislative assembly constituencies for administrative convenience." "AIADMK rejects the resolution regarding delimitation for political reasons. We support only the resolution concerning the reservation for women," he said.

BJP's lone MLA Bhograj (Nilgiris) questioned the TVK government on why the resolution is being tabled in a "hurried manner". "The BJP does not accept bringing such a resolution in immense haste. We oppose this resolution," he said.

Ruckus in RS over BJP MP's attire remarks

Smriti Kulkarni

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NEW DELHI: The Rajya Sabha witnessed a ruckus on Wednesday as the ruling side and the Opposition locked horns over alleged remarks on a House member's attire.

Communist Party of India (Marxist) MP John Brittas (Marxist) MP John Brittas alleged that the Bharatiya Janata Party's (BJP) Sushmita Devi had made a disparaging remark about his attire and moved a motion of privilege against her. Brittas was wearing a Mundu, a garment worn by a Hindu in Kerala. However, Devi later clarified



John Brittas and Sushmita Devi

in the House that she did not cast aspersions on any state's attire.

"Neither I nor any member has cast any aspersions on any state's attire," said Devi, who also submitted a notice to move a motion of privilege against Brittas for making a reference to "religion and a party's allegiance".

Soon after the House proceedings began, Brittas said the BJP MP had on Monday "repeatedly" disturbed him while he was speaking and proceeded to comment on his attire. "Verbal abuse is okay. We fight each other... But she repeatedly made derogatory remarks over my attire..." Brittas said in the House.

Speaking to HT outside Parliament he said, "While I was moving the statutory resolution, she came from her seat and was disturbing me. So I said, you see these turn coats are more enthusiastic in criticism... then she started calling me lungi wala, which is highly derogatory." Brittas had soon after filed a notice for moving a privilege motion against her.

Following Brittas's statement in the House, chairman CP Radhakrishnan said, "...I would advise that Hon'ble Members should be careful not to hurt the sentiments and feelings of fellow Members." He added that he would speak to both sides.

Union minister JP Nadda who is also the leader of the House said his party (BJP) does not subscribe to such statements. "We do not call it lungi; we call it dhoti," he said.

"The allegation is completely baseless, untrue and misleading. The BJP has nothing to do with any such organisation," Das said. He claimed the ritual was a response to alleged sloganeering linked to Islam at the venue. "Raising slogans associated with another religion at such a sacred place cannot be accepted or justified" he said.

"The purpose of the shuddhi yagna is not to create hostility towards any community, but to conduct a religious ritual to restore the religious and cultural identity of Ramleela Maidan," said Shri Ram Sena Dhamarth Seva Samiti secretary Ram Awasthi.

CAG FINDS SC/ST FUNDS USED FOR GEN CANDIDATES

Sanjay Maurya

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NEW DELHI: The Board of Apprenticeship Training (BOAT), Mumbai used ₹7.34 crore meant for Scheduled Caste/Scheduled Tribe (SC/ST) apprentices to pay stipends to General-category candidates, the Comptroller and Auditor General of India (CAG) has found.

The findings are part of CAG's report on the use of apprenticeship funds, comprising a series of audit on institutions under the education ministry.

According to the report, tabled in Parliament on Wednesday, BOAT Mumbai had received separate grants for SC, ST and General-category apprentices. During 2020-21 to 2022-23, it engaged 482,993 apprentices, including 10,79,362 SC and 3,60,737 ST candidates. The audit found a 25% shortfall in SC engagement and 72% shortfall in ST engagement against the required numbers.

Rather than retaining the unutilised funds for their sanctioned purpose or seeking the necessary approval for their use, BOAT Mumbai used ₹7.34 crore of SC/ST grants to pay stipends to General-category apprentices, it said.

₹1L-cr def min tender for 60 transport planes

Rahul Singh

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NEW DELHI: The defence ministry on Wednesday issued a tender worth around ₹1 lakh crore to buy up to 60 medium transport aircraft with an 18- to 30-tonne cargo carrying capacity, officials aware of the development said.

The tender has been issued to five Indian companies, including Tata Advanced Systems Limited (TASL), Mahindra Group, Adani Defence & Aerospace, Hindustan Aeronautics Limited and Reliance Defence, the officials said, asking not to be named.

The IAF, the world's fourth largest, is looking for a new transport aircraft with an 18- to 30-tonne cargo carrying capacity that met its growing airfield needs.

TASL has tied up with US firm Lockheed Martin, which has offered its C-130 Super Hercules aircraft for the MTA contest, and the Mahindra Group has teamed up with Brazilian plane maker Embraer, which has pitched its

three-300 Indian aircraft. The three other Indian firms have not yet announced partnerships to advance the project. The MTA contest aligns with the government's Make in India initiative to boost self-reliance in the defence manufacturing sector; the winner will set up a production line for the planes in India.

India is likely to conclude several big contracts for financial year 2025-27 to sharpen the air force's combat edge, including deals for the new transport planes, additional airborne early warning and control systems, and 114 Rafale fighter jets.

France recently responded to a letter of request sent by the defence ministry with a techno-commercial offer for the 14 Rafale fighter jets sought by the IAF, marking the next step in a deal expected to be worth ₹325 lakh crore. The French government submitted its proposal to the defence ministry on July 29, paving the way for negotiations on the government-to-government deal to begin.

₹10K PENALTY FOR DELAY IN AMBULANCE, NHAI TWEAKS NORMS

Soumya Chatterjee

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NEW DELHI: The National Highway Authority of India (NHAI) has mandated that ambulances deployed for all of its projects must reach crash sites within 10 minutes when the incident is within 10km of toll booths, failing which a ₹10,000 penalty will be imposed for each case.

The authority has also set a one-hour limit for accident victims to reach the nearest hospital after an emergency ticket is issued, with a ₹10,000 penalty for every delay. For incidents located further away, the permissible time will increase proportionally based on distance. Compliance will be checked through GPS data and the NHAI Care dashboard, with a ₹10,000 penalty for each incident where the prescribed time is exceeded.

Under the new norms announced on Wednesday, ambulance movement after an emergency ticket is accepted must be less than two minutes, with the movement to be verified through GPS data and the IMS (Intelligent Medical Software) Care dashboard. An additional ₹5,000 penalty will apply for every extra minute or part thereof. The circular also notes that the delay in response to accidents has been a major concern of the Supreme Court Committee on Road Safety and in a performance audit by the Comptroller and Auditor General of India.

parldiary

65 RLY EMPLOYEES HELD FROM 2025-26 FOR UNAUTHORISED TATKAL TICKET SALE: MIN

NEW DELHI: As many as 65 railway employees and 13,580 touts were arrested from 2023 until June 2026, railway minister Ashwini Vaishnaw informed the Lok Sabha in a written reply on Wednesday, while responding to questions on the alleged unauthorised sale of Tatkal tickets.

"Legal action is taken against offenders (including railway employees) under section 143 of the Railways Act, 1989. Further, 13,580 touts were arrested, and legal action has been taken against offenders under Section 143 of the Railways Act, 1989," Vaishnaw said.

ROAD CRASH DATA VARIATIONS DUE TO METHODOLOGY

NEW DELHI: The variation in India's official road crash death figures in the government's 'Road Accidents in India', 'Accidental Deaths and Suicides in India' and 'Crime in India' is due to differences in reporting methodologies adopted by some states and UTs, the Centre told Rajya Sabha on Wednesday. According to a MoTH report, 17,775 people died in road accidents in 2024. The NCRB's Accidental Deaths and Suicides in India reported 17,342 deaths, while Crime in India recorded 16,250 under "deaths due to negligence relating to road accident."

Beant Singh's murder convict declines 2-day custody parole offer

Jignasa Sinha and Navneet Sharma

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CHANDIGARH/NEW DELHI: Former Punjab chief minister Beant Singh's assassination convict Jagtar Singh Hawara on Wednesday declined the Delhi Prisons Department's two-day custody parole offer to meet his ailing octogenarian mother, as he sought regular parole, said people familiar with the matter. Custody parole is a short-term, supervised release of a convicted prisoner from jail. An armed police escort stays with him immediately after the time as they attend urgent family events. Hawara is currently lodged in Central Jail, Mandoli.

The development comes hours after CM Bhagwant Mann met Punjab governor and Union administrator Gulab Chand Kataria to push for a 10-day parole to Hawara, saying his government was willing to take full responsibility for maintaining the law and order situation during the release period.

"Based on the court's directions and security review, top officials granted Hawara custody parole for two days," he said, denying it, saying he does not want police protection. He's a high-risk prisoner and we have to deploy staff with him," said a senior official posted at the Delhi Prisons Department headquarters in Tihar, on the condition of anonymity. "Top officials will take a final call whether he'll be given custody parole or normal parole," he added.

Till the filing of this report, meetings were on between Hawara and Mandoli jail officials to negotiate the parole conditions. Hawara's counsel Maninder Singh, however, said they have not received any communication regarding parole from the authorities so far.

Earlier, after meeting Kataria, Mann said he was hopeful Hawara would be granted parole as the governor assured him that he would speak to the Union home secretary.

The report also flagged that the National Testing Agency (NTA) paid ₹54.24 lakh in avoidable penalty interest for delaying the deposit of TDS over three financial years; accreditation and technology deficiencies at the National Assessment and Accreditation Council (NAAC); ₹23.57 crore of infructuous expenditure by the National Institute of Open Schooling (NIOS) on irregularities involving ₹8.16 crore at the Central University of Tamil Nadu.

The CAG also flagged a series of governance, financial, procurement and human resource lapses at the IIM Rohtak, including an overstatement of its corpus fund by ₹267.45 crore and payment of ₹10.15 crore to vendors for services without complete recruitment records.

Kaziranga ESZ to be reduced to 1 km: CM

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GUWAHATI: Assam chief minister Himanta Biswa Sarma on Wednesday said the state government's move to reduce the eco-sensitive zone (ESZ) around Kaziranga National Park and Tiger Reserve (KNTR) from 10 km to 1 km would follow Supreme Court guidelines.

On August 8, the chief minister said the ESZ, around the UNESCO world heritage site, which is the largest habitat of the endangered one-horned rhinos, was 10 km "by default" and "since it is not feasible, the apex court would send a proposal to Centre within two months to reduce the limit to 1 km. He added that it was needed for development activities in the area including constructing a stadium.



Himanta Biswa Sarma

"The top court itself had stated that the ESZ would be of 1 km. But till the state government doesn't notify the ESZ, the limit of the zone would be 10 km. Once the state notifies the ESZ properly, it will come down to 1 km, which is what the apex court had specified," Sarma said.

In June 2022, the top court had ordered that ESZs of a minimum of 1 km should be declared around the protected forests, national parks and wildlife sanctuaries. But in April, 2023, following submission from states and Centre that such a uniform practice is not feasible, the apex court modified its order stating that a stringent observance of its earlier order was not feasible as the apex court had to more than man-animal conflict and hamper day-to-day activities of citizens.

Giving details of the current situation, Sarma said Prime Minister Narendra Modi had assured all support to help rebuild lives of those affected once the damage assessment survey underway in the state is completed. "We expect around ₹1,000 crore will be needed for rehabilitation. The PM has asked to ensure that no false claims for relief and rehabilitation are filed," said Sarma. "Till date around 8,000 families have been surveyed where damages of around ₹750 crore have been incurred. We will get help from Centre for rehabilitation, the PM has assured this," he added.

Sarma stated that by the time the survey gets over on August 30 around 10,000 affected families would be identified. Double checking of the details would happen after that till September 15, followed by another round of checks to ensure no one is left out.

'My election as Prez shows greatness of our democracy'

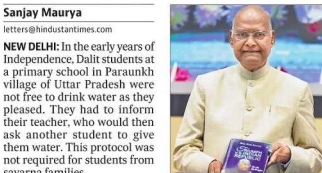
Sanjay Maurya

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NEW DELHI: In the early years of Independence, Dalit students at a primary school in Paraukh village of Uttar Pradesh were not free to drink water as they pleased. They had to inform their teacher, who would then ask another student to give them water. This protocol was not required for students from savarna families.

On July 25, 2017, one of those students, Ram Nath Kovind, took charge as India's second Dalit president, tracing a stunning arc — of a village lad from the rural hinterlands of Uttar Pradesh to the Central Hall of Parliament to be sworn in as the First Citizen of India.

The former president details



PM Narendra Modi with former president Ram Nath Kovind during the launch of latter's autobiography in New Delhi.

this broad journey in his memoir, Triumph of the Indian Republic: My Life, My Struggles, published by Rupa Publications. Kovind also leaves insights into his life after donning the office in July 2022 and offers

country symbolized the greatness of our democracy," he writes in the 334-page book, published by Rupa Publications. Kovind also leaves insights into his life after donning the office in July 2022 and offers

personal accounts of his interactions with and experiences of Modi, Atal Bihari Vajpayee and L.K. Advani. "It offers a glimpse into his interaction with Opposition leaders through his political career — as a BJP worker, as an MP, as governor, as President, as well as head of the high-level committee to take a call on simultaneous elections.

At the launch event, at Vigyan Bhawan, New Delhi, Kovind's life was a case study in how a person should treat society as "an equal partner in his success" rather than blame it for difficulties.

Modi recalled that Kovind lost his mother in a house fire when just four years old, saying the tragedy made him stronger. A neighbour helped raise him, while his father became his

"hero". Drawing a parallel, Modi said he was fortunate his mother Heeraben "lived beyond 100," but he could still "feel her absence". Heeraben died on December 30, 2022.

The 80-year-old throws his weight behind the "One Nation, One Election" plan, drawing on experiences through his career.

"ONOE is aimed at enhancing the efficiency of our electoral system, reducing the cost of elections, and enabling the government to focus on development without the frequent interruptions of staggered elections," writes Kovind.

"While it is a challenging endeavour, I believe it is essential for a more stable and collective democratic process," he adds.

Balancing act: K'taka CM allots portfolios to ministers

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BENGALURU: Karnataka chief minister DK Shivakumar on Wednesday allocated portfolios to 19 ministers inducted into his cabinet on August 3, ending weeks of uncertainty over their responsibilities a day before the state legislature's monsoon session.

The allocation followed discussions between Shivakumar and the Congress high command. The CM had visited Delhi on Sunday to meet AICC president Mallikarjun Kharge and party general secretary (organisation) KC Venugopal.

The sanctioned strength of Karnataka's council of ministers is 34, including the chief minister. With 33 ministers now in place, one berth remains vacant. The cabinet has no woman minister, despite pressure within the party to ensure representation for women.

Shivakumar has retained Finance, Cabinet Affairs, Department of Personnel and Administrative Reforms, Intelligence, Law, and other unallocated departments.

Among the major changes, Ramalinga Reddy has been shifted from Major and Medium Irrigation to Forest, Ecology and Environment after seeking a change of portfolio. N Chaluvar-



K'taka Cabinet portfolios

DK Shivakumar (CM) Finance, Cabinet Affairs, Intelligence, Law and other unallocated depts
B Zameer Ahmed Khan Housing
N Chaluvaraswamy Water Resources
K H Muniyappa Social welfare
B Nagendra Planning and Statistics

19 new ministers in DK cabinet assigned departments

ayaswamy has taken over Water Resources, including Major and Medium Irrigation.

KH Muniyappa has been moved from Food, Civil Supplies and Consumer Affairs to Social Welfare. UT Khader, who was earlier assigned Health and Family Welfare, has been given additional charge of Minority Welfare, Haj and Waft.

B Nagendra, who is facing allegations in connection with the alleged embezzlement of funds in the Karnataka Mahatma Vikrami ST Development Corporation, has been assigned Planning and Statistics. The opposition BJP has been demanding his resignation over this.

Five ministers have retained their portfolios: BZ Zameer Ahmed Khan (Housing), Shivvaraj Tangadagi (Backward

Classes Welfare and Kannada and Culture), Madhu Bangarappa (Primary and Secondary Education), Santosh Lad (Labour and Employment), and SS Mallikarjun (Mines and Geology and Horticulture).

Other ministers who continue with their existing portfolios include deputy chief minister G Parameshwara (Revenue and Water Resources), Information Technology and Biotechnology, and e-Governance, KJ George (Energy and Tourism), MB Patil (Large and Medium Industries and Infrastructure Development), Satish Jarkiholi (Public Works), Krishna Byre Gowda (Greater Bengaluru Development), Eshwar Khadare (Rural Development and Panchayat Raj), Yathindra Siddaramaiah (Urban Development), Byrathi Suresh

(Transport) and Sharan Prakash Patil (Medical Education and Skill Development).

The newly inducted portfolios have been assigned portfolios including Agriculture to Narendra Swamy; Food, Civil Supplies and Consumer Affairs to Raviwar Arshad; Municipal Administration to HC Balakrishna; Excise to KM Shivalingappa; Minor Irrigation and Science and Technology to Dr Jay Singh; ST Welfare to T Haghurthy; Muzrai, Fisheries, Ports and Inland Water Transport to SK Basavanthappa; Small Scale Industries and Public Enterprises to Vijayanand Keshappanavar; Sugar and Textiles to Rudrappa Lamani.

Laxman Savadi has been given Cooperation, Basavanna Reddy Higher Education and CS Puttanna Shetty Animal Husbandry and Sericulture. The allocation comes amid disaffection within the Congress, with several legislators who were seeking ministerial berths expressing displeasure after being left out. The absence of a woman minister is also expected to add to pressure on Shivakumar to fill the remaining berth with a woman.

The government has also appointed Congress MLA AS Ponnanna as political secretary to Shivakumar with Cabinet Minister status.



Vijay Malya

NEED TO MOVE ON: HC SEEKS CLOSURE TO MALYA'S BANK DEBT DISPUTE

MUMBAI: The Bombay High Court on Wednesday observed that the long-running dispute between fugitive liquor baron Vijay Malya and a consortium of lenders led by the State Bank of India over recovery of dues needed to "be brought to an end" in the interest of the country's economy.

A single-judge bench of justice Milind Jadhav made the observation while hearing Malya's 2020 petition challenging an order by a special Prevention of Money Laundering Act (PMLA) court, which had allowed the consortium to utilise assets confiscated by the Enforcement Directorate (ED) to recover unpaid dues. Malya was declared a fugitive economic offender in January 2019. On Wednesday, senior advocate Amit Desai, appearing for Malya, said the civil liabilities were over and the banks had already recovered around ₹50,000 crore from him against the original claimed dues of ₹6,20,33,33 crore plus interest.

"Actually, this issue needs to be put to an end. The idea is to move on... otherwise the relations and the economy of the country suffer," justice Jadhav said. mtc

7 killed in Mumbai landslide after rain

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MUMBAI: Seven people, including four members of a family, were killed and seven others injured after a landslide struck a row of tenement located near a hill in Mumbai's Kurla West around 3.30 am on Wednesday amid heavy rainfall, officials aware of the matter said.

The landslide hit three shanties in Gaushtia Chawl in Ashok Nagar locality of Chirag Nagar, civic officials said. The area is close to the suburbs of Kurla and Chhatkopar and boulders from the adjoining hill fell on the shanties, officials said, adding that seven persons were declared brought dead at the civic-run Rajawadi Hospital.

The deceased included Mohamad Samir Ansari (16), Sahil Husen Abdul Kazi (19), Arif Shaikh (28), his children Aban (2) and Manan (4), Marjina Arif Shaikh (27), and Viket Ramesh Yadav (27). Those injured are undergoing treatment, they said.

A 40-member team of the NDRF, along with 50 workers deployed by the L-Ward of the BMC and Fire Brigade teams, were engaged in the rescue operation, officials said.

Municipal commissioner Ashwini Bhide said the structures stood on government land and residents had been repeatedly warned about the danger. A civic official said notices had been issued as part of the BMC's annual pre-monsoon prepared-



Seven others were injured in the landslide, officials said.

ness measures. Residents, however, said they had nowhere else to go. Rescue operations were hampered by the narrow lanes in the neighbourhood, said chief fire officer Ravindra Ambalekar. "Even though we had the required equipment, we had to undertake the rescue work manually."

Attorniss Ansari, 45, a balloon seller, said, "My three sons, my nephew were asleep on the upper level, while my husband and I were beneath. We heard a loud thud and I tried to see what it was. The entire roof had crashed on our kids," she said.

Mayer Ritu Tawde announced financial assistance of ₹4 lakh to the family of each deceased person. The injured will receive medical assistance of up to ₹50,000 each. Maharashtra deputy CM Eknath Shinde said the government stands firmly behind the affected families.



Doctor assaulted by mob after cow hit; 4 held in U.P.

MEERUT: A 36-year-old government doctor was allegedly assaulted by a mob after his SUV hit a stray cow on a road in Uttar Pradesh's Badun district, police said on Wednesday, adding that four people have been arrested in connection with the incident.

Alapur SHO Madhav Singh Bhat said the accused, aged between 25 and 30, are residents of Bichpuri village and work odd jobs.

Woman out on drive gang-raped in Cuttack distt

BHUBANESWAR: A woman was allegedly gang-raped by a group of men in Odisha's Cuttack district while she was out on a drive with a friend, police said on Wednesday. The woman and her male friend were stopped on the Cuttack-Chandbali road late on Tuesday by a group of four to six men. The accused assaulted the friend and allegedly gang-raped the woman. The group then fled," said SP Vinita Agrawal, adding that a case was registered.

Strict action for remarks against Netaji: Suwendu KOLKATA: West Bengal chief minister Suwendu Adhikari on Wednesday directed the police to initiate strict action, including arrests, against those making derogatory remarks on Netaji Subhas Chandra Bose. "Police have been ordered to register cases under relevant sections of BNS and arrest the accused persons," he said. This comes after BJP Rajya Sabha MP Nagendra Nayak, also known as Ananta Maharaj, allegedly described Netaji as a "war criminal".

{ 16 CALLED FOR PERSONAL INTERACTION }

Interviews conclude for Ram Temple CEO

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LUCKNOW: The selection process for the first Chief Executive Officer (CEO) of Sri Ram Janmabhoomi Trust Kshetra concluded on Wednesday, with a high-powered search panel wrapping up the face-to-face interviews of 16 shortlisted candidates on the temple campus.

Announcing the completion of the interviews, Sameer Panda, Secretary of the Search Committee, said the process was "rigorous, transparent and comprehensive" and spanned multiple stages over several months.

The three-member panel comprised Justice (Retd) Pramod Kohli, Lt Gen (Retd) VK Chaturvedi, PVSIM, AVSM, SM, and nuclear scientist Dr Sushant Haware. "The selection experts assessed candidates' professional skills, leadership qualities, professional experience and technical competence," Panda said.

According to the committee, 5,585 applications were received in the first round of interviews. Candidates submitted detailed CVs showcasing management capabilities, experience in handling large-scale events and personnel, language proficiency, vision and strategic plans.

In round two, 1,580 applications were evaluated and final 111 candidates were called for online interviews to assess communication skills, leadership qualities, professional experience and technical competence.



The two-day process began on Tuesday.

logical outcome.

Finally, 16 professionals aged between 50 and 70 were invited for personal interaction in Ayodhya. They included Army veterans, retired IAS and IPS officers, and experts from government, corporate, education and IT sectors. "The evaluation focused on management skills, personality, vision, strategic planning, technology expertise and leadership potential. All 16 are accomplished professionals and significant achievers in their respective fields," Panda added.

According to the Trust, eight candidates were interviewed on Wednesday. On Tuesday, the eight candidates who appeared for interviews comprised four former IAS officers.

The Search Committee will now submit its report along with a panel of three names to the Sri Ram Janmabhoomi Trust Kshetra Trust. The Trust will conduct the final round of interviews and announce the CEO.

The CEO will be responsible for the day-to-day administration and overall functioning of the Ram Mandir, visited by hundreds of thousands of devotees daily.

{ ILLEGAL MINING THREAT }

100 armed guards to protect Chambal sanctuary

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BHOPAL: The Madhya Pradesh forest department will deploy more than 100 armed guards, permanent check posts and surveillance system to protect the Chambal Wildlife Sanctuary from illegal sand mining, officials said on Wednesday.

By September, we will set up 16 permanent check posts, install 35 CCTV cameras, and an Artificial Intelligence (AI) monitoring system at 44 sensitive ghats, where rampant illegal mining has been reported. The decision follows the Supreme Court's suo moti action against sand mining in the sanctuary," said Shyam Singh, superintendent of Chambal Wildlife Sanctuary.

He added that the forest guards would get 12-bore pump-action guns after the state government granted immunity to the forest guards in firearm use cases. Training sessions and police supervision will be conducted for forest guards to use firearms in emergencies. According to officials, 145 forest guards and 45 foresters from Morena division will

undergo training before deployment. Principal chief conservator of forests Subhrajnan Sen said, "We have already provided the required number of forest guards and foresters with firearms to



The Chambal sanctuary spans across MP, Rajasthan and UP.

check the illegal mining menace in Morena. Training will now be conducted with a standard operating procedure (SOP) to deal with those involved in illegal sand mining."

The Supreme Court took suo moti cognisance of illegal sand mining in the Chambal Wildlife Sanctuary, which spans 732 sq km across Madhya Pradesh, Rajasthan, and Uttar Pradesh. This mining has adversely impacted the home of gharials, dolphins, and tortoises.

In its observations, a Supreme Court bench of justices Vikram Nath and Sandeep Mehta said,

"The duties discharged by forest officers and forest guards within the National Chambal Gharial Sanctuary are not confined merely to protection of forests and wildlife. These personnel are entrusted with the highly dangerous task of safeguarding ecologically fragile and strategically significant wildlife habitats from organised illegal sand mining, poaching, and other unlawful activities."

The Supreme Court directed Madhya Pradesh, Rajasthan, and Uttar Pradesh to provide legal protection and prosecution immunity to frontline forest guards.

Marathi rule for Maha drivers starts Aug 18

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MUMBAI: Starting August 18, the licences of autorickshaws, taxi and app-based cab drivers who lack working knowledge of Marathi will be suspended for up to three months, and repeated violations could lead to license cancellation, officials said.

The state transport department on Wednesday amended the Maharashtra Motor Vehicles Rules, 1989, to provide for the action against non-Marathi speaking drivers of public vehicles, officials said.

State transport minister Pratap Sarnaik has directed the transport department to ensure

effective enforcement of the law. "These amendments will remove ambiguity in the rules and make the importance of working knowledge of Marathi for passenger transport drivers clearer," Sarnaik added.

According to a government notification, the amendments specifically clarify the requirement of practical Marathi for drivers and permit holders of autorickshaws, taxis and app-based motor vehicles fitted with electronic meters.

Officials said that under Rule 4(4) of the Maharashtra Motor Vehicles Rules, 1989, the words "and working knowledge of Marathi language" have been inserted after the word "ante-

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EVERY SATURDAY IN HINDUSTAN TIMES

24-YR-OLD RAPES MINOR RETURNING FROM M.P. SCHOOL

Shruti Tomar

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BHOPAL: A nine-year-old girl was allegedly raped in front of her brother while the two were returning from school in Madhya Pradesh's Bhopal district, police said on Wednesday.

According to police, the accused has been identified as Arvind Valmiki (24).

The accused stopped the siblings on their way home on Tuesday and offered to drop them on his motorcycle. He first took them towards agricultural fields near a canal but, upon spotting herders, went to a spot behind the school. There, he allegedly raped the girl. When he tried to leave, the girl intervened, Valmiki assaulted him," said in-charge of Mehgaon police station Ravindra Sharma. The accused abandoned the child at the scene and fled. The girl lost consciousness after the incident. Her brother managed to reach home and inform the family, who rushed her to hospital," he added.

The children's mother later reported the matter to police. Following medical examination of the girl, a case was registered against Valmiki under charges of rape and the Protection of Children from Sexual Offences (PoCSO) Act.

Police teams are conducting raids to arrest him, Sharma said.

No SC/ST faculty at IIT-Kanpur: RTI info

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LUCKNOW: The Indian Institute of Technology, Kanpur (IIT-K) has no Scheduled Caste (SC) or Scheduled Tribe (ST) faculty member at the professor level, and 376 of the total 957 sanctioned faculty positions are vacant.

The information was shared by the institute in February this year in response to a Right to Information application filed by Govind Kiran Kumar who claims to be national president of the All India OBC Students' Association (AIOSCSA). Kumar had filed the plea in January, seeking details of reservation implementation at the IIT.

Of the 257 professors, 254 belong to the unreserved (UR) category and three belong to the OBC category. There is no single SC or ST professor at IIT-Kanpur, according to a document signed by Pradeep Prakash, assistant registrar and CHD-2 on a letter head of the institute.

Representation remains limited even at lower academic ranks. Among 128 associate professors, IIT Kanpur has 112 UR, eight SC and four ST and seven OBC faculty members. At the assistant professor level, the institute has 136 UR, 17 SC, four ST and 36 OBC faculty members out of 193 positions, according to the data shared by the institute. Putting

together all teaching ranks, IIT-Kanpur currently has 25 SC faculty members and five ST faculty members out of 581 serving faculty members, it showed.

When asked to respond to this RTI reply that indicates the institute has no professors both in SC, ST category, IIT-K director Manindra Agrawal said, "This is not quite correct as there are many professors from reserved categories, but not officially recorded."

He added, "The office gave the wrong reply. We will put out a statement tomorrow."

According to the ministry of education, the Central Educational Institutions (reservation in teachers' cadre) Act, 2019, provides 15% reservation for SCs, 7.5% for STs, 27% for OBCs and 10% for EWS in faculty recruitment across central higher educational institutions.

HC COMMUTES DEATH SENTENCE TO RAPE-MURDER CONVICT IN HRY

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CHANDIGARH: The Punjab and Haryana High Court has commuted the death sentence to rape and murder convict in a 2022 case in Kaithal, Haryana, to a 50-year jail term.

"It is one of those rare cases where the line that separates the categories of the 'Rarest of Rarest' from 'Rare' is on the razor's edge. The biggest challenge before this court is that when the death penalty is not imposed and when executive policies permit early release, how do we save the girls from the perversity who after committing rape, kill them to destroy the evidence?" the bench of justice Anoop Chitkara and justice RC Dhimod said.

The seven-year-old girl was allegedly lured and abducted by the convict, Pawan alias Moni (then 21), from near her house, and he raped her at an isolated place.

After the sexual assault, Pawan throttled her to death, brought petrol and after sprinkling it on her dead body, set it on fire. The girl's half-brutal body was identified by her parents. Pawan was arrested and then convicted in the case with the help of CCTV footage and other evidence.



AI pilot claims he was on 'sleep medication'

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NEW DELHI: The commander of the Air India Phuket-Delhi flight that lost altitude suddenly on August 4, injuring several passengers, told investigators he had been struggling with sleep and was on medication prescribed by his family doctor, two people familiar with his account to the Aircraft Accident Investigation Bureau (AAIB) said. They spoke on condition of anonymity and described more than an hour of questioning by investigators.

The disclosure comes a day after it emerged the pilot's preliminary post-flight drug test was recorded as "non-negative," a screening result indicating a sample flagged for further analysis, and that his confirmatory test came back positive for cannabis.

The pilot told investigators he had been unable to sleep during his layover in Phuket. He said he had experienced sleep difficulty for some time because of personal circumstances, one of the persons said. He did not name the medication or say how long he had been on it, the person said.

DGCA rules require pilots on prescription medication to declare it to their airline. Non-disclosure can invite action from the operator. It was not clear if the pilot had done so.

The pilot said he slept for 30 to 35 minutes during the flight, used the washroom and returned to stand behind the first officer, the

THE DISCLOSURE COMES A DAY AFTER IT EMERGED THE PILOT'S POST-FLIGHT DRUG TEST WAS RECORDED AS 'NON-NEGATIVE'

two persons said. He was discussing the air conditioning system when the altitude event happened, and he was thrown to the cockpit floor, they said.

The first officer was flying the aircraft. The commander was the pilot monitoring, two people said. A cabin crew member on the observer seat, a role a departing pilot must assign when leaving the cockpit, helped him up, the persons said. It was the first detailed account from the cockpit crew of what happened aboard flight AI2379, an Airbus A320 registered as VT-EXO.

The full sequence of events inside the cockpit could not be independently established from the pilots' accounts to investigators. A copy of the aircraft's post-flight Centralised Fault Display System log, seen by HT, recorded nine warning messages between one minute at 9:32am IST — a time when the flight had entered over the coast of Odisha from the Bay of Bengal. The messages included low pressure across the Green, Blue and Yellow hydraulic systems in different combinations, low reservoir levels on the Yellow

and Blue systems, an autopilot disconnect and an elevator light-control fault. Two door emergency-exit sensor messages followed at 9:33am and 9:35am. No further hydraulic or elevator messages were logged for the next 43 minutes. A separate engine anti-ice fault was recorded at 10:16am, and a second autopilot disconnect at 10:52am. The second disconnect was not accompanied by any hydraulic messages, unlike the first. The log doesn't state a cause.

The pressure readings toggled across different system combinations within a minute rather than one system failing and staying failed. That pattern could allude to a transient event of the kind a sharp vertical excursion — or a sudden altitude loss, as reported by those onboard and the airline, — can produce through brief fluid movement in the hydraulic reservoirs, on a reading of the log by HT according to standard A320 fault-code references. A sustained mechanical failure would have thrown up more messages including a number to indicate

flight-trader data. A copy of the data places the altitude event within the same minute as the fault cluster. The aircraft was cruising at 36,160 feet when an altitude anomaly was recorded at 9:32am IST. It dropped to about 35,800 feet, a loss of around 360 feet, according to Flightradar data.

Air India did not issue a statement on the development till the time of going to press.

[HARIDWAR] AFTER TWO WEEKS OF YATRA

Kanwariyas leave 7k tonnes of waste behind

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HARIDWAR: The holy city of Haridwar is dealing with the after-effects of the Kanwar yatra, tonnes of waste lying in parking lots, camps, and even the Ganga ghats (bathing areas). According to Haridwar's municipal commissioner Nandan Kumar, around 7,000 tonnes of garbage was generated in the two weeks of the Kanwar yatra, when pilgrims from across north India travel to the city to pick up Ganga water, which they then transport back, without stopping or in a relay, to their homes.

In recent years, the yatra has become increasingly popular, and also loud, with pilgrims driving into town on trucks rigged with giant speakers. This year, according to Kumar, around 10 million pilgrims visited Haridwar on just Sunday and Monday, the last two days of the yatra. All told, 48 million pilgrims did.

The city administration, used to dealing with around 250 tonnes of garbage, is now clearing mounds of clothes, plastic bottles, and other waste. "Sanitation workers



The Haridwar district administration has launched a drive from August 12 to 18 to restore cleanliness in the district. HT PHOTO

have been deployed in groups around Har-ki-Pauri and the Mela zone. Waste collection and disposal is also being carried out in city markets, lanes, roads and parking lots on a war footing," Kumar said.

In view of the huge volume of waste generated during the Kanwar fair, the Haridwar district administration has launched a drive from August 12 to 18 to restore cleanliness in the district. "Heaps of garbage and waste are lying at Ganga ghats, in the Kanwar Mela zone, along the Kan-

war patri and throughout the pedestrian routes used by kanwariyas to travel, rest and camp, as well as at vehicle parking areas. While civic agencies are already involved in the clearance, it is vital that local residents, the saint community, religious organisations, educational institutions, volunteers and tourists also participate," said chief development officer Lalit Narayan Mishra. The work is being monitored on site and online by senior officials to ensure time-bound clearance of waste, he said. Over 1,000 sanitation person-

nel and 100 outsourced workers have been deployed by civic authorities for the drive, along with 80 garbage collection, transportation and disposal vehicles.

The Akhil Bharatiya Akhara Parishad, the apex body of recognised akhadas, has informed the district administration that monks and office-bearers of various akhadas would participate in the cleanliness drive.

"Kanwar pilgrimage is an ancient tradition and in recent years the number of kanwariyas has crossed the four-crore (40-million) mark, so waste generation is bound to increase manifold. We fully support the administration's initiative to seek voluntary participation from individuals. By participating in this post-Kanwar cleanliness drive, people will also derive spiritual satisfaction as they will indirectly be helping clean Ganga and reduce pollution," said Akhara Parishad president Mahant Ravindra Puri of Niranjanji Akhada.

Environmentalists warned that pollution levels in the Ganga could rise if the waste is not removed in time and rain washed

it into the river.

"Such a large floating population of kanwariyas certainly has a bearing on pollution levels in the Ganga. Bacterial content increases when garbage, sewage, plastic, polythene and human waste enter the river. The risk of microplastics being absorbed also remains a major concern. The use of plastic sheets, bottles and cans and dumping of clothes and bamboo in the Ganga should either be discouraged or prohibited," said Gagan Matta, assistant professor, department of environmental science, Gurukul Kangri University.

Seers also expressed concern over waste, plastic, polythene and used clothes being left at Ganga ghats. "Kanwariyas, pilgrims, tourists and local people should be sensitised against littering and leaving waste, garbage, polythene bags and clothes at Ganga ghats. We regard Ganga as a deity and mother, but through such acts, knowingly or unknowingly, we pollute the sacred river," said Mahamandaleshwar Swami Haricharanand of Bada Udasin Akhada.

[JHARKHAND]

Amid protests, ex-CM warns of hunger strike

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RANCHI: The health condition of four protesters, who are undergoing treatment at Ranchi's Sadar Hospital following hunger strike in Jharkhand over alleged irregularities in recruitment examinations, is stable, officials said on Wednesday, even as former chief minister Raghubar Das threatened a hunger strike and ABVP announced nationwide protests.

The agitation, led by the JPSC-JSC Reforms Manch, entered its 19th day with pay aspirants continuing their dharna at Jaipal Singh Munda Stadium in Ranchi. A core committee member of the Manch said two protesters, Habiba and Rahul Kranti, were admitted on August 11 and August 7, respectively. Two other protesters, Devendra Nath Mahto and Mahendra Pratap, who are protesting under the banner of JPSC-Chhatra Manch, are also receiving treatment in the same hospital.

"The health condition of all four students is stable. Check-ups and regular monitoring of their health are being done periodically," the deputy superintendent of Sadar Hospital Dr Bimlesh Kumar Singh said. He said Mahto was still fasting, but his health was stable, while Kranti was taking a liquid diet. Mahto has been on hunger strike for the past 11 days. He was admitted on Monday as his health deteriorated following his participation in a march to the assembly by agitating students.

State health minister Irfan Ansari said he had visited the hospital and met the protesters. "I am urging students not to risk their lives by sitting on a hunger strike. The government has already constituted a team, dialogues have been held, and more will be held," Ansari said.

Meanwhile, BJP leader and ex-CM Raghubar Das, addressing the protesters at the stadium, said: "If the state government fails to recommend a CBI probe within a week, I will be forced to sit on a hunger strike here". The ABVP said it would organise demonstrations at more than 1,200 universities and in every district across country.

(With PTI inputs)

DELHI HC QUIZZES META ON RIGHTS MANAGER TOOL

NEW DELHI: The Delhi high court on Wednesday questioned Meta on why access to its Rights Manager tool, which enables copyright owners to identify and manage unauthorised use of their copyrighted content on Facebook and Instagram, is not available to all individuals.

A bench of justice Anup Jalaram Bhamhani directed the company to explain its eligibility criteria for granting access to the tool and the basis on which such access is denied. "Why does everybody not have access to it then? It is like giving the key to the robber and not to the owner of the house," he remarked.

The court made the observation in a suit filed by Mohit Kumar, an Indian e-commerce and AI business coach who creates educational content under the handle "Rise with Mohit".

Kumar alleged that scammers registered his videos as their own through the tool and used the system to issue copyright strikes against his account.

Meta's counsel submitted that the strikes were reversed and content removed pursuant to those strikes were reinstated.

The court, however, issued summons and listed the matter for September 24. SHRUTI KAKKAR

No uniform guidelines on rehabilitation plan in demolition cases: SC

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NEW DELHI: The Supreme Court on Wednesday declined to entertain a plea seeking a rehabilitation policy for people affected by demolition of unauthorised constructions, saying a uniform framework was neither feasible nor prudent as the issue falls within the policy domain of states and Union territories.

Disposing of the petition filed by the Centre for Law and Good Governance, a non-profit organisation, the court allowed the petitioner to approach states and UTs with its concerns. It said governments would be at liberty to formulate or revisit their existing policies on the issue.

A bench headed by Chief Justice of India Surya Kant said, "It would be difficult and not prudent for this court to lay down a uniform policy framework to be applied across various states."

The bench, also comprising justices Jaynalya Bagchi and V Mohana, said the circumstances could vary from state to state and may warrant different policy frameworks.

The petitioner, represented by advocate Surat Singh, pointed out that the Supreme Court has recognised the right to shelter as part of the right to dignity and the right to life under Article 21 of the Constitution. Singh said Andhra Pradesh, Telangana and the NCT of Delhi have settlement and regularisation policies, while similar policies do not exist in many other states where unauthorised colonies are suddenly ordered to be demolished.

The court said, "On one hand there are rank illegal constructions. At the same time, there are also people, largely belonging to economically marginalised sections, who occupy tracts of public land and require alternative accommodation. We cannot let the state from taking any suitable policy decision. If the policy is arbitrary, unreasonable or does not accommodate due process, it will be open to judicial review."

"These issues must be examined case by case. They cannot be addressed through a collective policy framed by this court," it said, allowing the petitioner to approach states and UTs.

HAIR FULL

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FIR. VOICE. LAST WORD.

9 houses, church burnt, Manipur village on edge

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IMPHAL: At least nine houses and a church were burnt after unknown armed miscreants allegedly opened fire and set fire to a Naga village in Manipur's Kangpokpi district, officials aware of the matter said on Wednesday.

The incident took place on Tuesday around 9.30 pm at Tokpa Liangmai Naga village, near Tumoukpokpi Thangal village, they said, adding that the residents of nearby villages rushed to the spot and helped contain the blaze, while additional security personnel were deployed in the area.

A statement issued by the Tokpa Naga Village Authority on Wednesday condemned the alleged armed attack and arson.

"The assailants reportedly resorted to indiscriminate firing and set fire to nine residential houses, one church and other properties causing extensive damage and displacing affected families," the statement said.

The village authority alleged that CRPF personnel and Kangpokpi police stationed at Kala-

phar High School, near the incident site, did not respond immediately despite repeated appeals.

It demanded an FIR and investigation, adequate security for villagers, and immediate relief, rehabilitation and compensation for affected families. The Liangmai Naga Council, Manipur also condemned the incident and alleged that armed men from another community were behind the attack. The council urged the government and security authorities to act with urgency and impartiality.

The incident comes amid escalating tensions between Kuki-Zo and Naga communities in the district.

Arms, ammunition, explosives recovered

Security forces and other law-enforcing agencies in Manipur have recovered a total of 1,422 arms, 7,010 rounds of ammunition and 1,137 different explosives since February 5 till August 11, the state government said on Wednesday. Highlighting stepped-up security operations along side a sustained political outreach aimed at restoration of peace in the violence hit state.

Must communicate GST arrest order, 'reasons to believe': SC

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NEW DELHI: The GST authorities cannot arrest a person without first communicating the order authorising the arrest and the "reasons to believe" recorded by the commissioner, the Supreme Court ruled on Wednesday, stressing that withholding such reasons could have "drastic consequences" for an accused's right to liberty.

A bench of justices Dipankar Datta and Sheel Nagu said an arrest order under Section 69 of the Central Goods and Services Tax (CGST) Act must be communicated to the affected individual because the order is a "sine qua non" (an essential condition) for seeking anticipatory bail. The court said such communication would not impede an ongoing GST investigation and, instead, would reinforce an accused's right to seek legal protection.

"The order under Section 69 of the CGST Act, as held, being a sine qua non to seek anticipatory bail, it would be an anomaly to hold that the order need not be communicated at all," it said.

THE SC ALSO SET ASIDE A HC ORDER GRANTING FUTURE GROUP NON-EXEC DIRECTOR SUNIL BIYANI A 1-WEEK PROTECTION IN A GST PROBE

The court held that disclosing the reasons behind the arrest authorisation was crucial as such an order is open to judicial review by constitutional courts. The accused must be in a position to challenge both the order and the "reasons to believe" recorded by the commissioner.

"If Section 69 were read as it is, without there being any requirement of disclosure of the reasons to believe, withholding of reasons could have drastic consequences on the right to liberty of the accused," it noted.

The judgment also clarified that communication of the arrest order need not wait until after the person is arrested. "Without such communication, question of arrest would not

arise," it said.

The judgment came even as the bench set aside a Bombay high court order granting Future Group non-executive director Sunil Biyani one week's protection from arrest in a GST probe, holding that the high court could not have granted such relief before concluding that his anticipatory bail plea was premature.

The top court found this course of action impermissible, but at the same time directed the GST commissioner to communicate the Section 69 order to Biyani, after which he could pursue whatever legal remedy was available to him. It said that the order could be communicated electronically, including through email, in addition to the modes permitted under the Bharatiya Nagarik Suraksha Sanhita and other permissible methods.

Referring to Rule 8 of the CGST Rules, the bench noted that a person seeking GST registration is required to provide an email address and mobile number. "This would enable an accused to seek remedy that the law provides to him, if so advised," it said.

FM: PUBLIC CAPITAL NO SUBSTITUTE TO PVT INVESTMENT

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NEW DELHI: The government believes that public capital must act as a catalyst, not a substitute for private investment, Union finance minister Nirmala Sitharaman said on Wednesday.

She said policy measures have been taken to support this principle, citing examples of viability gap funding (VGF), hybrid annuity model (HAM), infrastructure investment trusts, national infrastructure pipeline and the PM Gati Shakti.

VGF supports financially constrained but socially desirable projects, HAM ensures balanced risk-sharing in road infrastructure and credit enhancement mechanisms help improve project bankability, she said in her keynote address at the seminar on 'The Role of the New Development Bank in Mobilising Private Capital in Member Countries' on the sidelines of the Brics Finance Ministers' and Central Bank Governors meeting in Jaipur.



{ SIKKIM TUNNEL } NHPC PAPERS REVEAL

Methane risk flagged months before blast

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NEW DELHI: NHPC Ltd had flagged methane as a risk at the Teesta VI hydropower project in Sikkim months before a methane explosion in an under-construction tunnel killed 25 workers on July 20, documents on the company's website show.

The documents record a methane leak in January and show that safety measures and equipment to monitor the gas were subsequently recommended and sought.

The blast occurred in the head-race tunnel (HRT) of the 500-MW Teesta VI project in Namchi district. NHPC said it was caused by a "sudden burst of suspected methane gas" trapped inside the rocks, leading to an explosion, dense fumes and toxic gases. Twenty-five workers trapped after a rockfall blocked the tunnel died. A probe into the incident is still underway.

An NHPC document prepared to justify nomination-basis contract awards for April-June 2026 records that on January 14 there

was "a sudden leak of flammable methane gas during heading excavation at HRT Face 4A".

"Several personnel from the executing agency...suffered burn injuries in the incident. Consequently, excavation work was suspended with immediate effect," the document said.

A subsequent safety audit by CSIR's Central Institute of Mining and Fuel Research (CSIR-CIMFR) recommended strict implementation of handheld, rugged methanometers for real-time monitoring.

It is not clear from the documents whether all these recommendations had been fully implemented before work resumed.

An expression of interest (EOI) issued by NHPC on July 10, just 10 days before the explosion, sought expert agencies to address challenges affecting excavation, including "seepage, ingress of water/slush, cavity formation, face collapses, and the presence of methane gas".

HT reached out to NHPC for comment but no immediate response was available.

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MASTER PLAN 2047

tal sustainability, infrastructure, large conservation, urban regeneration and citizen-centric governance," DDA said.

The decision was taken at a DDA meeting chaired by lieutenant governor Tarunjit Singh Sandhu and attended by vice-chairman N Saravana Kumar and other members of the authority. DDA also approved the policy allowing reconstruction and redevelopment of old DDA-built two-storey dwelling units in accordance to the 2016 Unified Building Bye-Laws (UBBL), which seek to simplify the building plan approval process and reduce procedural requirements, as well as a change in land use for a metro depot for the Rithala-Kundli corridor in Narela.

The new Master Plan for Delhi was approved for further consideration, aligning Delhi's long-term vision with Hon'ble PM Shri Narendra Modi's vision of 'Atmanirbhar Bharat@2047'. Deliberated on a roadmap for sustainable and inclusive urban growth, with greater Ease of Doing Business, Ease of Living, and green spaces, greener capital for all. Delhi has a pivotal role to play in shaping this journey," Sandhu posted on X.

The significant change proposed by the agency was to the definition of the 22km-long Yamuna floodplain, earlier treated as single protected O zone where development was largely restricted. MPD 2047 divides it into O-1 and O-2. HT has learnt. While no construction or development will be permitted in O-1 — which falls within the defined 15-25 year floodplain, or the manner in which the banks are proposed to be defined based on the probability of floods once in 25 years — O-2, the area outside this zone, will allow specified recreational activities, including sports and green spaces, subject to regulations, an official aware of the matter said.

DDA has revealed details of the Master Plan yet and it is unclear how the O zone will be demarcated.

The draft MPD-2047 had proposed that the Yamuna floodplain — a low-lying riparian zone with a 4% annual probability of flooding and designated as O-zone by successive master plans — would be included in the city's database of green-blue infrastructure. The draft plan had specifically stated that "no permanent construction shall be permitted in the floodplain" and proposed public access through 75-100 metre-wide greenways along embankments, with cycling and walking trails and spaces for passive recreation. But the new plan, officials explained, creates a distinction between the "core floodplain" and the "outer buffer".

Another significant change will be in 70 villages on the city's periphery through a Green Development Area (GDA) framework, allowing regulated commercial and institutional activity in areas where such development was earlier restricted, HT has learnt.

These will include all 70 villages on the outskirts or periphery of Delhi, including Tiki Kalan, Mitraon Dhamra, as well as areas with farmhouses like Mehrauli, Chhatrapur and Sabari.

The GDA framework — which was detailed in the earlier 2041 plan — brings together around 70 villages falling in the Green Belt and Low-Density Residential Area (LDRA) under a common planning framework. Of these, 47 were earlier governed by rules that restricted new residential and commercial construction, and 23 didn't.

Now, the new plan has paved the way for commercial development in all 70 villages along the periphery of Delhi with Gurgaon and Noida-like vertical development, allowing higher Floor Area Ratio (FAR), said an official aware of the matter.

"The emphasis on vertical development is linked to the limited availability of land in the already urbanised parts of Delhi. Instead of continued horizontal expansion, redevelopment can allow existing plots and built-up areas to accommodate more housing, commercial activity and other uses through higher-density forms of development, subject to infrastructure and development-control norms," another official added.

A senior DDA official said, "The policy will encourage green development and will ensure seamless development of infrastructure and road network within and around GDA. For these areas, minimum 12m, 18m and 30m roads are being considered."

The authority also approved a uniform policy for reconstruction and redevelopment of old DDA-built two-storey units on individual plots. The policy

will apply to older housing schemes such as Naraina Viceroy.

According to DDA, several housing schemes developed under MPD-1962 have two-storey built-up units on individual plots that are more than five decades old and have become structurally deficient. Under the new policy, such units will receive redevelopment rights on par with vacant residential plots.

DDA also approved amendments to UBBL-2016 to simplify the building plan approval process and reduce procedural requirements. The changes seek to de-link the requirement of obtaining prior no-objection certificates from the Delhi Pollution Control Committee, Chief Inspector of Factories, Delhi Jal Board and Forest Department for obtaining building permits.

"This is part of the government's broader deregulation exercise and is aimed at reducing red tape, simplifying and facilitating faster approvals," a DDA official said.

Another major decision involved 19.63 hectares of land in Narela. The DDA approved its change in land use from "recreational" and "public and semi-public" to "transportation" for development of a metro depot for the Rithala-Kundli corridor.

The proposed extension of the Delhi Metro's Red Line from Rithala to Kundli is expected to connect north-west Delhi, Rohini and Narela with areas of Haryana.

"The authority also approved several changes to the proposed change from residential to public and semi-public use to be placed before the public for objections and suggestions," an official said.

Similarly, a 24.400 sq metre plot adjacent to the Sarojini Nagar residential area was proposed for change from transportation (rail circulation) to residential use. Public notices will be issued for objections and suggestions. Three plots at Copernicus Lane, measuring 8,494.35 sq metres and allotted by the Land and Development Office to Bharatiya Vidya Bhavan, were approved for change from residential to public and semi-public use. The proposal is linked to the institution's plans to expand into higher education and research related to Indian traditional knowledge systems.

DDA ALSO GAVE NOD TO AMENDMENTS TO THE 2016 UNIFIED BUILDING BYE-LAWS (UBBL) TO SIMPLIFY THE BUILDING PLAN APPROVAL PROCESS

FCRA BILL SENT TO JPC

supplementary list of business introduced a resolution in the Lok Sabha on Wednesday afternoon to form the 31-member JPC with 21 Lok Sabha members and 10 Rajya Sabha members. A Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) member is expected to lead the panel.

The Opposition — which tried to pressure the government to scrap the bill — said it will join the JPC. "Even in the JPC, we will continue to strongly oppose this bill and will allow these unconstitutional and coercive provisions to become law," said Congress general secretary KC Venugopal.

"On one side, the RSS is getting donations from foreign countries, while on the other side, the government is trying to target minorities and NGOs. The government should withdraw this bill," he added.

Parliamentary affairs minister Kiren Rijiju hit back, saying that the Congress and others had been demanding for days that the bill be referred to a JPC. "Yet, even when we are referring such an important bill (to a panel), these people have objections. If KC Venugopal or a member of any other party finds anything objectionable in this bill, or if there is any point they wish to oppose, they can present their views in the JPC. The JPC will have sufficient time; hearings will be held, and then people will also be invited to participate. Instead of being pleased about this, they are speaking against it."

The minister denied any pressure on the government to refer the contentious bill to a House panel and argued that the decision was taken to allow extensive discussion.

Later in the day, he attacked the Opposition. "I am totally frustrated. For the first time in my life, I am witnessing a scenario where the government wants a discussion in Parliament, yet the Opposi-

tion is running away from it. It is hard to imagine this, because in a parliamentary democracy, it is the Opposition that demands a discussion while the government provides the answers," Rijiju told reporters.

"We are saying that if the Congress states even tomorrow morning at 11:00am that they are ready for the discussion, we will extend the time. You should ask Congress why they got scared and why they fled," he added.

He also referred to Shah's letter to Birla, where the home minister said that Rijiju — on behalf of the government, during the business advisory committee meeting — gave consent for a discussion in Parliament on student protests.

"I would also like to mention that earlier, at the request of the Opposition, a discussion has already taken place in the current session of Parliament on the Public Examinations (Prevention of Unfair Means) Amendment Bill, 2025, in which no honourable Member of Parliament from the Opposition expressed any views in the House regarding the NEET examination. Despite this, the government is ready to discuss this issue once again," Shah said in the letter written in Hindi.

The minister has asserted that he wanted to be present in the House during the scheduled time to participate in the discussion and was ready to answer all questions. "Seriousness emerged only through discussion and dialogue in a democracy. I have unwavering faith in democracy and democratic institutions, and it is my belief that this House is meant precisely for discussion and dialogue," he wrote.

But the Opposition dismissed the offer. Gandhi alleged that Shah lacked the courage to come to Parliament, reiterating the demand that Shah come to the House and speak on police excesses at Jantar Mantar.

"The Opposition has clearly said that we are not interested in Amit Shah giving us a lecture. When I say 'we', I mean the younger generation of this country. Who shot the students? Who gave the order to beat up the students with lathis

with nails? Did Amit Shah give this order to shoot our children? If he did, then he should resign. For the last 20 days, Amit Shah has been missing. The home minister of India has no courage; he cannot come to the House," Gandhi said.

"When a man lacks the courage to speak the truth, his silence speaks for him. Amit Shah's silence is his confession," he added.

Formed to review a bill, a joint committee of Parliament initially gets three months' time but is allowed extensions. Currently, Parliament has 18 such panels.

The bill was introduced in the Lok Sabha in the previous session but was not brought for passage after protests by the Opposition and controversy in then poll-bound Kerala. The bill had evoked sharp reactions from Opposition leaders, particularly Kerala lawmakers, as Christian groups alleged they might be targeted under the new law.

The amendments establish a designated authority for "a comprehensive framework for vesting, supervision, management and disposal of foreign contribution and assets, including provisional and permanent vesting." A provision stated that the government can appoint a "designated authority" to take over, manage, or sell assets created from foreign funds by a non-governmental organisation whose licence under FCRA was cancelled, suspended, or simply not renewed.

The bill plans to do away with section 15 of the current act that limits the scope of authority to manage the activities of the organisation, utilise foreign contribution or dispose of the assets created out of it, in case adequate funds are not available for running such an activity.

In the meeting of opposition parties on Wednesday morning, it was decided that the parties will participate in the JPC panel and not repeat their boycott of the panel on the set of bills to automatically remove ministers if arrested for 30 days. Congress leader Jai Ram Ramesh said he told the opposition leaders "We can't repeat the same mistake".

N CHANDRASEKARAN

Tata Trusts had agreed in July 2025 to recommend a fresh five-year term for Chandrasekaran. The recommendation was subsequently taken up by the Tata Sons board on 24 February.

However, the proposal was not carried through after Noel Tata sought a clear roadmap for the performance of some of the new businesses launched under Chandrasekaran's watch, including e-commerce, aviation and semiconductor, according to a person familiar with the matter.

In his resignation letter on Wednesday, Chandrasekaran said his decision not to seek another term was linked to the reappointment proposal not receiving unanimous support from the board.

"My current tenure as the Chairman of Tata Sons comes to an end on Feb 20, 2027," Sir Dorabji Tata Trust and Sir Ratan Tata Trust had unanimously resolved and recommended the extension of my next term for a period of five years, which was recorded and recommended by the Tata Sons Nomination and Remuneration Committee and the Board," Chandrasekaran wrote in his letter.

"Subsequently, the resolution was tabled in the Tata Sons Board on Feb 24, 2026. However, the proposal was not carried through because one of the Board Members did not support it, and in the absence of unanimous support, I chose to defer the decision," he said.

The Tata Sons board comprises Chandrasekaran, Noel Tata, TVS Motor Company chairman emeritus Venu Srivivasan, Tata Group chief financial officer (CFO) Saubrah Agrawal, and independent directors Harish Manwani and Anita Marangoly George.

The February episode was a rare challenge to Chandrasekaran, who had previously enjoyed the confidence of the Tata Sons board. It also exposed growing differences between the holding company and Tata Trusts.

The two sides continued discussions after the February meeting. Over the past six months, Chandrasekaran and Noel Tata held at least two closed-door meetings to discuss

CHANDRASEKARAN SAID HIS DECISION WAS LINKED TO THE REAPPOINTMENT PROPOSAL NOT RECEIVING UNANIMOUS SUPPORT FROM THE BOARD

the group's roadmap, one executive said.

In the last week of June, senior executives from Air India, Tata Electronics and Tata Digital also made presentations to Noel Tata, Chandrasekaran and members of the Tata Sons board, the executive said, adding that the presentations did not resolve Noel Tata's concerns about the financial performance and longer-term roadmap of the new businesses.

Tata's concerns span some of the Group's biggest bets under Chandrasekaran—from the turnaround of Air India and the creation of an e-commerce platform through Tata Digital to battery manufacturing through Agratas, iPhone assembly for Apple, and semiconductor manufacturing through Tata Electronics.

The four businesses reported a combined loss of ₹29,924 crore in FY26, according to Tata Sons' annual report. Air India alone reported a loss of ₹22,238 crore, more than double the previous year.

The Tata Trusts have yet to comment on Chandrasekaran's decision not to seek a renewal.

An email sent to Tata Sons was not immediately answered.

The next challenge

Chandrasekaran's decision not to seek another term now leaves Tata Trusts facing the immediate challenge of finding his successor.

Under Tata Sons' Articles of Association, the next chairman will be appointed by a five-member selection committee. Three members are jointly nominated by the Sir Dorabji Tata Trust (SDTT) and Sir Ratan Tata Trust (SRTT), one by the Tata Sons board, and two independent members are selected by Tata Sons. The chairman of the selection committee is chosen by SDTT

and SRTT from among their three nominees.

SDTT and SRTT own 27.98% and 23.56%, respectively, of Tata Sons. Other Tata trusts own 14.4%, giving the philanthropic entities a combined 65.9% stake in the holding company of the diversified Tata Group. The remaining stakes are owned by the Shapoorji Pallonji Group (18.38%), the Tata Group companies (2.88%) and seven individuals (2.87%).

The succession process, however, could be complicated by a separate dispute involving the Tata Trusts. The Maharashtra charity commissioner has prohibited SRTT from taking decisions on holding board meetings, creating uncertainty over the Trusts' ability to participate in Tata Sons' governance.

The restriction could also affect the Tata Sons AGM scheduled for 18 August. Under section 87 of the Tata Sons Articles of Association, SRTT and SDTT jointly nominate directors representing the majority shareholders who can attend the shareholder meeting.

Since SRTT is currently unclear how to take decisions, it is unclear how the Tata Trusts will nominate a member for the AGM. If the Trusts are unable to do so, questions could arise over whether the meeting will have the required quorum.

Governance tensions

The governance tensions between Tata Trusts and the Tata Sons board had surfaced earlier as well.

In September 2025, Vijay Singh was removed as a director of Tata Sons after four of the seven trustees opposed his continued nomination by the Trusts. Subsequently, trustee Mehli Mistry's renewal on the boards of SDTT and SRTT failed to receive unanimous approval.

The differences also spilled into questions over the future structure of Tata Sons. In a surprising turn of events, Venu Srivivasan, a Tata Sons board member and Tata Trusts trustee, advocated listing Tata Trusts, a position viewed by some as contrary to the interests of the Tata Trusts.

(With Inputs from Reuters)

CASH ROW INQUIRY

knowledge, control or accountability in relation to the storeroom where the currency was found, while drawing adverse inferences from his decision not to enter the witness box.

The 126-page report, tabled in both Houses of Parliament on Wednesday, said that the "cumulative record" established the presence of substantial currency notes within the official premises, the judge's failure to satisfactorily explain their presence, his failure to preserve the material and the subsequent disappearance of the currency, while finding no substantiated defence capable of displacing the evidence before the committee.

It remains to be seen whether the tabling of the report marks the end of the matter, or whether Parliament will still explore the possibility of initiating or pursuing proceedings for Justice Varma's removal through the impeachment process despite his resignation.

The committee was headed by Supreme Court judge Justice Aravind Kumar and comprised Bombay high court Chief Justice Shree Chandrashekar (since elevated to the Supreme Court) and senior advocate BV Acharya. The committee examined oral and documentary evidence before arriving at its findings.

The report's findings are significant not merely for the controversy over the unexplained currency found after the fire, but also for the committee's assessment of the conduct expected of a constitutional judicial office-holder when confronted with circumstances affecting the credibility and integrity of the institution.

IT REMAINS TO BE SEEN IF PARL STILL EXPLORES THE POSSIBILITY OF STARTING PROCEEDINGS FOR HIS REMOVAL THROUGH THE IMPEACHMENT PROCESS

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OPINION

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{ OUR TAKE }

Flying into turbulence

Indian civil aviation is beset with crises while probe bodies act as moral arbitrators, not enforcers

Imagine being on a morning flight, bleary-eyed after a night-out or more in Phuket — a favourite party destination for a certain kind of reveller — and hoping for a few hours of rest before returning right in the middle of the mundane. But the flight becomes your worst nightmare, suddenly dropping at least 300 feet, with turbulence initially being blamed for the incident. So far, there's nothing out of the ordinary. Now, add to the mix a pilot allegedly high on marijuana and technical problems, and it's the stuff of nightmares for even seasoned flyers. That's the curious case of AI-2379.

The Indian aviation sector, especially Air India, has lurched from one crisis to another. As if price upsurges, undisciplined flight schedules, technical glitches, non-existent customer care, and one of the worst air crashes in history were not enough, air travellers now have to factor in intertemporal pilots. Are passenger safety commanders observed only in violations? As the probe into the Ahmedabad crash (also an Air India flight) that claimed 260 lives continues after one year without even a draft report, speculation is rife about collusion and cover-ups. This lack of transparency from all stakeholders — government, investigator, aircraft manufacturer, airline — makes claims to conduct any enquiry with competence and fairness suspect. Whether the captain of the Phuket flight was indeed abusing narcotics or whether there is merit to the theory about mechanical trouble, therefore, is of secondary importance. Whatever version the airline chooses to put forth will always be contested. To the injured passengers (and crew) on the flight, these are but marginalia. What matters is only that a serious lapse on the part of the airline endangered the lives of 137 passengers and eight crew members aboard the Phuket-Delhi flight. The captain failing the dope test twice should be seen as a serious lack of safety mechanisms and not merely an individual's personal and professional failing. What will it take for the industry (and Air India, whose presiding duty appears to be Murphy) to fasten its seatbelts and put inviolable processes in place? More importantly, why do probe agencies and regulators end up acting merely as moral arbitrators, in most cases, and not enforcers? The current case of the high pilot may have become a meme-fest only because of a fortunate lack of fatalities, but it was a lucky shot that everything didn't go up in smoke.

Telling apart graft and grit in decision making

In a country where a senior bureaucrat's estimate of notional loss helped take down a government, determining what constitutes loss and how investigators assign responsibility in such cases is important indeed. This week, the Central Vigilance Commission (CVC) revised its master circular and said that financial and non-financial losses caused to a government department need not necessarily be considered the result of corruption or malfeasance.

This is a sensible distinction. The apex vigilance body — which oversees and supervises the vigilance aspect of organisations owned or controlled by the Centre, including State-owned companies — is correct in stating that there might not be any correlation or causation between corruption and loss (or notional loss). The business of governing a complex and diverse country such as India will always require some degree of adventurous decision-making, some courage, some out-of-the-box thinking, and some leaps of faith. It is important to ensure that such decisions are not plagued by conflicts of interest, political or economic considerations or harm to national interest or security. But not every decision might result in the desired outcome, even without any foul play or malfeasance. If anything, our bureaucracy has been guilty of favouring the status quo over the dynamic, the safe over the risky. As long as the creative decision-making is sanctioned, reasonable and informed, there is no reason it should be penalised as corruption.

No modern nation-state can tolerate corruption because it gnaws at the foundation of the country and hollows out public faith in institutions. Over the past seven decades, corruption has become endemic in many public bodies and bureaucracy due to deep politicisation, entrenched power structures, nepotism and lax oversight. While the CVC's nuanced position is welcome, it must not become an excuse for preferential treatment or a relaxed view on corruption.

So far so good: Don't lose sight of reforms

The next phase of India's economic journey will depend as much on availability of short-term buffers to navigate crises, as on using the lessons from the West Asia conflict to deepen reforms

If someone had told me in December 2025, while I was contemplating the revised outlook for the Indian economy for 2026, that two months into the year, a war in West Asia would send global crude oil prices rocketing past \$100/bbl, the Strait of Hormuz would be shut for at least six months and 54% of India's gas imports would get stuck, I am sure I would have painted a rather gloomy picture. But here we are, oscillating between having a peace deal and a ceasefire violation, oil at \$70/bbl in one instance and \$100/bbl in another, and the Strait of Hormuz open & free and closed & chargeable. Despite such a backdrop, India's growth in the April-June quarter is estimated to be at least 7% year-on-year (y-o-y). After the war in West Asia broke out, it became apparent that India was more at risk of a "gas shock" than a "crude oil shock," given access to alternate suppliers and strategic reserves for the latter. Accordingly, the Essential Commodities Act was invoked, industries were tiered depending on national importance,

and rationing of gas supplies began. The outcome was predictable: a sharp, short-lived contraction in fertiliser production; production lines in ceramics and glass factories grinding to a halt; the hotel and restaurant industry facing intermittent shut-downs; petrochemical factories focusing on LPG throughput; and civil aviation and port cargo traffic taking a hit. While these disruptions were severe and extended beyond production lines to livelihoods, a return to normalcy began by mid-April.

At the time of writing this, high-frequency indicators were showing steady improvement, even with lingering uncertainty surrounding the truce and widening concerns around maritime routes. Arguably, these developments guided the Reserve Bank of India to revise its gross domestic product (GDP) growth forecast up by 10 basis points (bps) to 6.7% y-o-y at the August Monetary Policy Committee (MPC) meeting. With the current crude oil price lower than the assumption used in June, the Consumer Price Index (CPI) inflation forecast was also eased up about 100 bps. A sharper downward revision of the core CPI inflation forecast by 40 bps to 4.3% y-o-y was notable. It reinforces the view that current and imminent inflationary pressures are led by a supply-side shock and administered price increases are not a reflection of demand-pull inflation. That

said, the MPC statement underscored that it will maintain a close vigil and remain resolute in its commitment to align inflation with the target of 4% in the medium term, noting that "although generalised inflation pressures continue to remain modest so far, the risks of higher food, fuel and other input prices translating into a broad-based increase in inflation persist".

So, with inflation rising to 5%, do we expect RBI to hike rates soon? Not necessarily. Even though the mandate for the MPC is to keep CPI inflation at 4% (±2% band), the composition and the path matter. With core inflation closer to 4% and adjusted for precious metals, still below 4%, the MPC may opt to wait and watch before commencing the hiking cycle. As for stance, a "neutral" stance gives two-way optionality in terms of rate action, and unless RBI has reasonable clarity about the next move, it could retain a neutral stance. So, while August delivered a neutral pause, we expect it to persist through the remainder of 2026.

It would be remiss to conclude a monetary policy discussion without alluding to currency. Having addressed the capital account concern by announcing a slew of measures to attract foreign capital inflows, RBI and the ministry of finance did the heavy lifting alongside the June 2026 meeting. With more than \$50 billion of flows on account of these measures already in



Aastha Gudwani



The tensions in West Asia have exposed India's energy import dependence yet again.

(and more to follow), the balance of payments (BoP) situation appears on track to turn to a likely surplus of \$30 billion in FY27 (from an expected deficit before these steps came into effect). This eases the tail risk for the currency, allaying fears of any out-sized depreciation of the rupee vis-à-vis emerging market peers. So, the extent of fundamental warrant, any rupee depreciation could be modest and gradual.

With resilient growth, contained demand-driven inflation, and an outlook for gradual currency depreciation, one would have expected Indian government bonds to get a place in the Bloomberg Aggregate Index, but the wait appears to have gotten longer than previously envisaged. Should operational difficulties get ironed out, leading to inclusion, foreign portfolio investment in Indian government bonds could rise, offering additional support to the currency.

The tensions in West Asia have

exposed India's energy import dependence yet again, and as the economy steers through this volatile geopolitical global environment, looking inward and beefing up energy security is fast becoming a policy priority. Ramping up strategic petroleum reserves, greater focus on renewable energy, dedicated resource allocation for oil and gas exploration and other such initiatives are some of the steps that the government has already announced to insulate India's external account from energy price and availability gyrations in the future.

The next phase of India's economic journey will depend as much on the availability of short-term buffers to navigate crises as on using the lessons of this period to deepen reforms, strengthen energy security and attract global capital.

Aastha Gudwani is India chief economist, Barclays. The views expressed are personal

Mecca pact: Regional fix to hedge against a fickle US

Saudi Arabia, Pakistan, and Turkey signed a defence agreement on August 7 in Mecca, Islam's holiest city, stating that an attack against any of the three countries will be regarded as an assault on them all. The Mecca Joint Defense Agreement comes amid growing doubts about the US as a security provider, even as Saudi Arabia signed a civilian nuclear pact with Washington in July.

In 1963, the then-Saudi Crown Prince Faisal told US ambassador Parker T Hart that "after Allah, we trust America," underlining the depth of their relationship. The Saudi-US ties remain strong, but successive US administrations have sought to reduce their involvement in West Asia. President Donald Trump has vocally articulated the need for allies across regions to spend more on their defence and take more responsibility.

The Trump administration's National Defense Strategy is categorical in saying the US is stretched and cannot shoulder the responsibility alone amid simultaneous threats. Months before taking office for the second time, Trump in 2024 went to the extent of saying he would encourage Russia to attack any NATO member that fails to pay its bills.

In the Persian Gulf, the US left allies to fend for themselves when Iran retaliated after the February 2026 attack. The Associated Press (AP) reported in March how Trump confronted mounting discontent from these allies. It quoted a Gulf official complaining about the American focus on defending Israel while their stock of interceptors was depleting. In May, The Washington Post reported the US military used more of its advanced missile defence interceptors to defend Israel from Iranian attacks than its ally spent defending itself. The situation is believed to have hastened Gulf allies' reassessment of the American role as a provider of stability and continuity, and prompted them to assume that role themselves.

Pakistan, a nuclear power, and Turkey, NATO's second-largest military power, are part of Saudi Arabia's separate maritime alliance to guard shipping in the Red Sea from the attacks of Iran-backed Houthis in Yemen. Red Sea is key to Saudi economic diversification. It became one of the most vulnerable waterways as it emerged as an alternative route for energy exports and international trade following the closure of the Strait of Hormuz as a consequence of the Iran war.

Houthi sought to expand the regional conflict to the Red Sea. On July 25, they hit Saudi Arabia's Red Sea oil export hub five days after announcing a blockade of Saudi shipping through the Bab al-Mandab Strait. Saudi Arabia, the guardian of Islam's holiest cities and an energy powerhouse, had pursued tensions with Iran over the years as it pursued the ambitious Vision 2030 to diversify its economy.

Saudi Arabia is widely believed not to be

averse to normalisation with Israel either. But it found common ground with Pakistan, with whom it has had a complicated relationship, amid regional concerns about Israel's aggressive posturing. Israel's leaders have spoken about potential conflict with Turkey after attacking Yemen, Lebanon, Syria, Qatar and Iran, prompting West Asian countries to seek collective defence pact.

In February, Israel's Prime Minister Benjamin Netanyahu spoke about a new hexagon of alliances to outflank an "emerging radical Sunni axis," as he announced his Indian counterpart Narendra Modi's visit to Israel, Greece and Cyprus, the other two countries in the proposed alliance, have historically had hostile ties with Turkey. The Mecca pact assumes greater significance against this backdrop.

The pact was signed less than a year after Riyadh inked a defence agreement with Pakistan, which has deployed troops and defences in Saudi Arabia. Riyadh has negotiated and managed escalation with Tehran through Islamabad. The Mecca pact consolidates Pakistan's role in a changing regional landscape and embeds their influence on the international stage and divert attention from economic crisis and political repression at home.

The Mecca pact could bolster Pakistan's historically transactional ties with the US as Washington seeks burden-sharing from allies, and Islamabad's relevance as a mediator with Iran is not going to last forever.

The Mecca agreement also marks an inflection point, over a century after Britain and France signed the secret Sykes-Picot Agreement to redraw West Asia's boundaries, literally by drawing straight lines on a map with a ruler and a pencil. Britain promised Arabs independence after World War I if they revolted against the Ottoman Empire, from whose rubble present-day Turkey emerged. Britain and France did the opposite by dividing them without allowing Arabs to determine their future. The colonial borders, which remain largely intact, were created to channel, exploit and embed the rival State structures. Many problems in the region can be traced to the Sykes-Picot Agreement.

The US replaced Britain as the major player. It has for decades used its influence to advance its interests in West Asia in defending Israel, ensuring the free supply of oil, and checking Soviet influence during the Cold War. The US is not a net energy exporter and no longer relies on imports. The stalemate with Iran has made the American people more war-weary. It is expected to increase pressure to end foreign entanglements, explaining why Saudi Arabia needs to expand its partnerships.

The Mecca agreement also seeks to address security issues with regional solutions. It is too early to predict whether it will succeed. But it carries immense symbolic significance over a century after Western powers arbitrarily divided West Asia and made the region dependent on others for security. The region is now attempting to build a new security architecture. Whether it can overcome the long shadow of Sykes-Picot's colonial geopolitics, however, remains to be seen.



Sameer Arshad Khatlani

{ DONALD TRUMP } PRESIDENT, THE US

We own it (the Strait of Hormuz). And at some point, maybe they'll (Iran) do something, and then they get blown away

Claiming full control of the Strait of Hormuz



A new vocabulary of gender jurisprudence

There are moments when clinical legalism can obscure human suffering. In March 2025, a ruling by the Allahabad High Court in a POCSO case served a chilling reminder. The case involved a 14-year-old girl subjected to a harrowing sexual assault after being lured onto a motorcycle. The accused broke the string of the girl's pyjama to "bring down" the garment and groped her. The High Court characterized these acts as "mere preparation" rather than an "attempted rape." The Supreme Court swiftly intervened, setting aside the order and describing the reasoning as reflective of a "totally insensitive and inhuman approach."

Recognising that earlier attempts at sensitising the judiciary had not produced the expected results, the Court asked the National Judicial Academy to constitute an expert committee to examine what had worked, what had failed, and on-ground experiences. Its task was to improve courtroom terminology and help move them beyond procedural compliance towards an approach that places human dignity at the heart of judicial reasoning.

The resulting 2026 handbook titled *Judgments and Gender: Sensitivity and Compassion in Writing* judgments recognises that words are charged. Terms such as "helpless female," "lost her chastity" and "outraging modesty" are patriarchal and may reintroduce trauma. The guidelines ask judges to leave that language behind. Its recommendation to move away from the archaic term "prosecutor" and use terms such as "survivor" or "complainant" finally aligns court vocabulary with constitutional promises.

The need for such a recalibration is long overdue. But it is only the beginning. The Handbook itself identifies a persistent "Language-Justice Gap." A softer vocabulary cannot, by itself, undo stereotypes of the "ideal victim" — distrusting a survivor for delayed reporting, a lack of visible injuries, or behaving calmly after trauma. The deeper shift, therefore, must be in how the law understands sexual violence. It must move away from treating it as an injury to a woman's "chastity" or honour and recognise it as a violation of her bodily autonomy.

The late must allow patriarchal assumptions about women to determine legal reasoning.

The focus on expression and language, though well-intentioned, only addresses part of the problem. Conventional jurisprudence

has historically failed vulnerable litigants through gender-insensitive legal, clinical detachment, and moral judgement of survivors. Perhaps the most tangible contribution of the 2026 handbook is the "witness as guest" mechanism. It recognises that survivors can experience a second form of victimisation within the courtroom itself, particularly when their needs and dignity are treated as secondary to that of the accused.

The committee's recommendations, grounded in an empirical study of trial court judgments and stakeholder responses, seek to strengthen these protections. One startling finding was that four of every five stakeholders were entirely unaware of the Witness Protection Scheme. For many survivors, then, rights exist only on paper. The new guidelines seek to change this by shifting the responsibility from the survivor to the State. Judges are now legally obligated to inquire about a victim's safety and legal representation at the very first instance. The requirement of written compliance within 48 hours for providing legal assistance could help turn legal aid from a distant entitlement into an immediate procedural guarantee.

This shift is a necessary response to a scarred history of gender jurisprudence. It is a painful line that connects the 1992 brutalisation of Bhanwari Devi to the Vishakha Guidelines of 1997, from horrifying tragedies in Delhi, Unnao, Kathua, Hathras, and Kolkata to the legislative responses that followed. Each episode has demanded reform. Each reform has promised that the system will do better next time. The difficulty is that there is always a "next time."

For too long, the judiciary has been a site where public morality and judgements about women were allowed to outweigh constitutional rights. We must arrive at a system where women do not have to bleed before the law takes notice. Protecting the rights of survivors is not an act of paternal sympathy for helpless victims; it is a rigorous, evidentiary method that takes trauma seriously while protecting the dignity of the survivor as a non-geographical constitutional right.

The handbook may change how the courts speak; but we will have to wait to see if it changes how they listen.

Ashish Bharadwaj is the pro vice-chancellor of WPU Goa. Insiyah Vahanvaty is a socio-political commentator and author of 'The Fearless Judge'. The views expressed are personal



Ashish Bharadwaj



Insiyah Vahanvaty

HT

Zhu Rongji, China PM who overhauled economy, dies
BEIJING: Zhu Rongji, who as China's premier pushed through reforms at state-owned companies that cost tens of millions of workers their jobs, and who helped engineer China's entry into the World Trade Organization, has died. He was 97. **BLOOMBERG**

\$900 million to be spent on WH construction
WASHINGTON: The Trump administration is set to spend at least \$900 million for construction projects on the White House (WH) grounds, the Washington Post reported on Wednesday. **REUTERS**

44 drown after ferry capsizes in Zimbabwe lake
HARARE: Search and rescue operations continued on Wednesday after a government passenger ferry capsized on Zimbabwe's Lake Kariba, claiming at least 44 lives, authorities said. **AFP**

Rod Stewart cancels tour dates after heart surgery
LONDON: British rock star Rod Stewart, 81, has cancelled forthcoming US tour dates after having a heart operation, his social media announced. A message posted late Tuesday on his Instagram page said the rascally-voiced rocker has "successfully undergone a routine coronary stent procedure". **AFP**

Iran: No progress on reviving interim peace deal with US

Reuters

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DUBAI: Iran and the United States remain at loggerheads over efforts to agree a permanent end to the war in the Gulf, according to a senior Iranian source, who said there had been no progress in talks to revive the interim deal agreed in June and define a time frame to implement it.

The comments were a further blow to hopes for a resolution to the crisis, following new attacks on shipping in the region on Tuesday.

The deal agreed in June declared an "immediate and permanent termination of military operations on all fronts", but quickly unravelled, with US President Donald Trump saying it was "over" on July 7 and Iran's foreign ministry declaring it "suspended" a week later.

The US accuses Iran of failing to honour an agreement under the deal to reopen the vital Strait of Hormuz shipping route. Tehran says Washington has reneged on its commitments, including lifting a blockade of Iranian ports and releasing frozen Iranian assets.

"One of the issues that is being discussed via mediators is the US returning to the interim agreement and defining a timeframe for implementing the commitments. There has been absolutely no progress on this issue," the Iranian source said.

There was no immediate comment from Washington.

Thousands of people have been killed in the conflict, mainly in Iran and Lebanon, since the US and Israel launched attacks on Iran's infrastructure in countries including Oman, Jordan, Kuwait,



Damaged cargo vessel Tihamah near Murad, Yemen, on Tuesday. The vessel was attacked in the Bab el-Mandeb strait. **REUTERS**

TRUMP: U.S. WILL KEEP CONTROL OF STRATEGIC STRAIT OF HORMUZ, PRAISE BE TO ALLAH

WASHINGTON: President Donald Trump on Wednesday said the US is in control of the strategic Strait of Hormuz and will "keep it".

"The U.S.A. has total control over the Strait of Hormuz. I THINK WE WILL KEEP IT! Our Naval Blockade is being called, by everyone, 'A WALL OF STEEL', and there is nothing Iran can do about it," Trump wrote on his Truth Social platform. "They have no Navy, they have no Air Force, their remaining soldiers are unpaid, the

IRGC is decimated and fleeing, and their 'Leadership' is uncertain, at best! They have No Money — Their country is 'shot'. All they have is FAKE NEWS and 300% INFLATION, and getting worse! Iran is all talk and no action, the Bully of the Middle East No Longer. Praise be to Allah!"

Trump has repeatedly claimed the US controls the strait, which is vital for the flow of energy and other commodity shipping through the Middle East. **AFP**

Israel, the United Arab Emirates and Saudi Arabia.

The June interim ceasefire agreement set a 60-day period, extendable by mutual consent, within which Iran and the US were expected to reach a final deal limiting Tehran's nuclear programme and lifting US sanctions.

The Iranian source dismissed a report on Wednesday from Turkey's Anadolu news agency that

quoted Pakistani government sources as saying they had agreed to extend that 60-day period.

Iran's top security official, Mohsen Rezaei, said on Tuesday that the Strait of Hormuz would remain closed unless the US accepted Iran's conditions to end the war. That followed a new demand from Trump on Monday that Iran should pay compensation for people killed in 50 years of wars, attacks and protests.



Donald Trump, Natalie Harp

TRUMP CHOSE HIS FAVOURITE AIDE OVER ADMIN OFFICIALS DURING TURKEY ESCAPE

HT Correspondent

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NEW DELHI: US President Donald Trump chose his inner circle favourite White House aide Natalie Harp over senior administration officials when he escaped from Air Force One to travel in a decoy jet via a catering truck in Turkey last month.

Harp, 35, was among a select group of Trump's inner circle who fled a Nato summit in Ankara on a military flight because of a credible Iranian assassination threat. The Washington Post (WaPo) reported.

Among those who joined Trump in the military flight included White House deputy chief of staff Dan Scavino, and Walt Nauta, the director of Oval Office operations.

Scavino, Harp and Nauta have worked for Trump at his Mar-a-Lago estate in Florida during the four years between his presidencies, after many others who served in the first Trump White House distanced themselves following his two impeachments and criminal investigations.

As per the report, Trump made sure to bring Harp with him, who has remained a constant in the president's life for years. Author Michael Wolff revealed in his book "All or Nothing: How Trump Obscured America" that Harp's reputation with Trump became so severe that she was even flagged by the Secret Service as a potential security risk.

Top officials, including Secretary of State Marco Rubio, top White House aide Stephen Miller and Treasury Secretary Scott Bessent, remained on Air Force One after Trump was made aware of the Iranian threat.

Border situation with India generally stable, says China

Rezaul H Laskar

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NEW DELHI: China on Wednesday sought to play down reports of a military standoff with India in the Arunachal Pradesh sector of the Line of Actual Control (LAC), with a foreign ministry spokesman saying the "border situation is generally stable".

The comments by Chinese foreign ministry spokesman Guo Jakun came a day after the external affairs ministry said that the state of border affairs has ramifications for overall India-China ties, and that the two sides have agreed to use diplomatic and military mechanisms to "avoid misunderstanding and miscalculation" along the border.

The Indian side has officially offered no clarity on the current status of the standoff in Arunachal Pradesh sector, though people familiar with the situation said on condition of anonymity that problems first

COMMENTS CAME DAY AFTER MEA SAID THAT THE STATE OF BORDER AFFAIRS HAS RAMIFICATIONS FOR OVERALL INDIA-CHINA TIES

emerged in the remote Taksing area of Upper Subansiri district in early July and there had been several face-offs between Indian and Chinese troops.

"The China-India border situation is generally stable at the moment. China and India held the 36th meeting of the Working Mechanism for Consultation and Coordination on China-India Border Affairs (WMCC) last week," Guo told a media briefing without going into details.

Guo, who was responding to questions on videos on Indian social media claiming

stepped-up Chinese military activity in Arunachal Pradesh, did not deny the reported standoff in the region.

The questions also referred to a recent military incident with India and increased Chinese military activity near Arunachal Pradesh.

Guo said India and China have "agreed to maintain communication via diplomatic and military channels and jointly uphold peace and tranquillity in the border areas".

These remarks echoed comments by external affairs ministry spokesman Randhir Jaiswal at a media briefing in New Delhi on Tuesday.

India and China are currently engaged in rebuilding their relations, which plunged to a six-decade low in 2020 following a military face-off in Ladakh sector of the LAC and a violent clash at Galwan Valley in June that year that left 20 Indian soldiers and at least four Chinese troops dead.

Ukraine strikes Russia's key Black Sea naval base

AP & Reuters

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KYIV/MOSCOW: Ukrainian anti-ship missiles, jet-powered aerial drones and sea drones blitzed a major Russian naval base on the Black Sea coast in a "unique" nighttime operation, Ukrainian President Volodymyr Zelenskyy said on Wednesday.

The Ukrainian military "carried out a unique operation targeting the naval base in Novorossiysk — the last major stronghold of the Russian fleet in the Black Sea," Zelenskyy said in a social media post.

The attack struck air defences, piers and other port infrastructure in the Krasnodar region city, he added. Krasnodar region governor Vladimir Koldratyev said that hundreds of Ukrainian

drones attacked Novorossiysk, Anapa and Gelendzhik and the Temryuk district of the region overnight. Russian air defenses downed more than 500 Ukrainian drones, the defence ministry in Moscow stated.

Putin threatens seizure of European ships

President Vladimir Putin said on Wednesday that Russia will respond in kind if European countries start to seize Russian merchant vessels and the commander of Russia's Pacific Fleet said his forces were ready to "inspect and detain" foreign vessels from what he called hostile states. Some European governments have said they are exploring tougher maritime enforcement measures against ships suspected of sanctions evasion.

RIVAL TO AIRBUS, BOEING, CHINA'S JET MAKES FIRST COMMERCIAL FLIGHT

BEIJING: China's homegrown C919 jet completed its first international commercial flight on Wednesday, a symbolic step towards Beijing's goal of challenging the decades-long aerospace dominance of Boeing and Airbus.

The narrow-body jet has been billed as a potential competitor to Boeing's 737 or Airbus's A320, though the aircraft has yet to receive approval from American or European regulators.

The C919 jet, produced by the state-owned Commercial Aircraft Corporation of China (COMAC) and operated by Air China, departed Beijing at 3:37pm (0717 GMT) on Wednesday. It landed in Mongolia's capital Ulaanbaatar at 4:58pm (0855 GMT), according to public flight data. **AFP**

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Chandra's stint: A tale of 2 halves

Can Rishabh Pant remain ahead in an intensifying three-way tussle?

The 28-year-old has been India's No.1 keeper. But the emergence of Jurel and Kishan will keep him on his toes

Somshuvra Laha
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KOLKATA: Rishabh Pant has built much of his Test career by refusing to play the game conventionally. If there is a ball to hit, he hits it. If there is a field to unsettle, he tries to unsettle it. The head coach spoke of players needing to understand the difference between playing with freedom and "playing to the gallery". He didn't name Pant. He didn't have to. The subtext was difficult to miss.

For much of Pant's India career, the argument in his favour was simple—while he could pull off stuff like that, his batting was sufficiently transformative, his wicketkeeping had improved sufficiently and his match-winning record was so compelling that India could afford the occasional indiscretion. Pant was not merely India's wicketkeeper. He was a tactical weapon. Perhaps he still is, but that monopoly has now disappeared.

The more immediate threat is Dhruv Jurel, who has gone about establishing himself with almost none of Pant's noise. Jurel's value is precisely that he doesn't need to dominate a game to influence it. His wicketkeeping is assured, his temperament has impressed and his batting has suggested that he can occupy the No 6 or No 7 role without India having to compromise elsewhere.

But the more intriguing challenge comes from Ishan Kishan. He has always possessed an element of Pant's attraction—left-handed aggression, an appetite for risk and the ability to turn a quiet passage of play into something chaotic. What has changed is the evidence that his attacking game is no longer merely potential. His performances at the T20 World Cup, followed by a productive period in domestic cricket, have strengthened the case for treating him as a serious red-ball option

rather than simply another explosive white-ball batsman. That distinction matters.

Pant's greatest advantage has always been that he can change the mathematics of a Test match. A counter-attacking 80 can be worth considerably more than a sedate hundred after the opposition has already controlled the game. Kishan offers a similar proposition.

Indeed, at this stage of their careers there is an uncomfortable question for Pant: Is he still India's go-to wicketkeeper? Former chairman of selectors MSK Prasad, under whom India had perfected the balance of making Virat Kohli Saha keep at home and Pant away, still believes Pant is non-negotiable to India's demands. "Don't forget that he was the number one wicket-keeper batter in the world. I mean, a year ago," said Prasad. "He is the only wicket-keeper batter in the history of Indian cricket to get runs in all SEENA counties. So, a few innings here and there cannot write him off."

Few can argue this point. Pant's record remains the standard against which any challenger must be measured. But selection is rarely about reputation alone. It is also about what comes next.

And that is where Pant finds himself in unfamiliar territory. His last ODI and T20I for India was in 2024, making him a one-format player now. That is never easy. His method has always carried an inherent contradiction. The same instinct that allows him to dismantle an attack can also expose him to unnecessary dismissals. When it works, it looks like genius. When it fails, it can look like indiscipline. The difference between the two is often a matter of timing or match situation, something that India probably realised the most during the South Africa Tests last year.

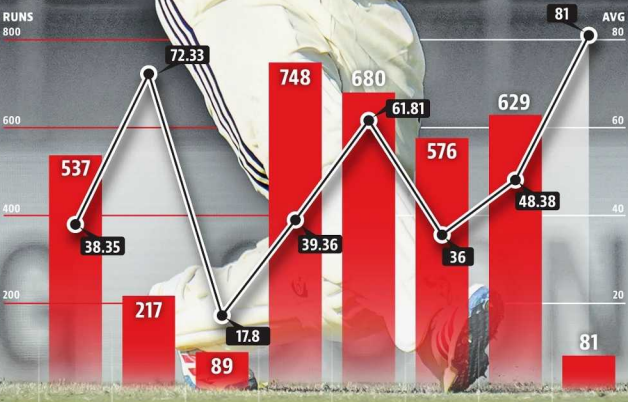
As his latest innings in the warm-up game suggest, Pant's genius is inseparable from his willingness to take risks. The problem, from a coach's perspective, begins when the situation demands restraint and the instinct to thrill wins. Until recently, Pant could believe that the Test wicketkeeper's slot was his to lose. But with Jurel and Kishan actively jockeying for their seats as well, Pant may have to face some competition.

Pant's greatest gift has never been his technique. It has been his ability to impose himself on a phase to drastically alter the context of a game. The next stage of his career, however, may require a different kind of judgement—knowing when to attack, and when the attack can wait. He has done that before. With the landscape rapidly changing though, Pant may want to be more consistent at it.

Crunch time for the batter Pant

Rishabh Pant's free-spirited batting is a sight to behold in Test cricket, but the India wicketkeeper is facing questions after some crucial failures and the rise of challengers to his spot. A look at how the numbers stack up ahead of the Sri Lanka Tests.

Pant in Tests



Year	2018	2019	2020	2021	2022	2024	2025	2026
Mat	8	3	3	12	7	9	7	1
Inns	14	4	5	21	12	17	13	1
HS	114	159*	29	101	146	109	134	81
100s	1	1	0	1	2	1	2	0
50s	2	0	0	5	4	3	4	1

IN HIS LAST 5 INNINGS	27 v South Africa Eden Gardens	02 v South Africa Eden Gardens	07 v South Africa, Guwahati	13 v South Africa Guwahati	81 v Afghanistan New Chandigarh
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'Doubt whether I'll keep playing for much longer'

Associated Press
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MIAMI: Lionel Messi shared a tribute to his late father, Jorge, on social media on Wednesday, opening up about how difficult it was to lead Argentina to the World Cup final and expressing uncertainty about whether he will continue playing soccer.

"I don't know what I'm going to do without you," the post said in Spanish, shared on Messi's Instagram. "I don't know how to keep going. All I ever did was play soccer, and now I have serious doubts about whether I'll keep doing it for much longer."

Jorge Messi—who played a fundamental role in the soccer star's career, serving as his agent and managing his business affairs—died Saturday. He was 68.

Lionel Messi led Argentina to a runner-up finish in this summer's World Cup. In the team's first match, against Algeria, he was visibly emotional after scoring the first of his three goals. He said later that he wept for "a reason unrelated to sports."

"You asked me to play in this last World Cup so many times and just before it started when you took a turn for the worse," the post said. "It was the first time you weren't going to be at the tournament. But mom kept telling me that you were going to get better



Lionel Messi.

and that you'd be well enough to travel. I kept telling you that we were going to make it to the final so you could travel."

The post added that Messi "wanted to win it" for his father.

"I couldn't," the post continued. "My legs had nothing left. This time I tried to push beyond what my body could handle, but I couldn't. I never managed to feel right." Messages of support for the Messi family have poured in over recent days. Messi had returned to his native Argentina and missed his MLS club Inter Miami's recent Leagues Cup match against Monterrey. Inter Miami declined the group phase of the tournament Wednesday night against León, though coach Guillermo Mosquera said Tuesday there is no timetable for Messi's return.

For Brazil tie, India pull out of FIFA ASEAN Cup

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KOLKATA: India has pulled out of the FIFA ASEAN Cup because it clashed with the friendly against Brazil. The decision was taken on Wednesday.

"We are unable to participate in the FIFA ASEAN Cup due to our commitment with the Brazil football federation," AIFP president Kalyan Chaudhary said. "There were technical issues so since only four games can be played during the window (September 21-October 6), India play Brazil in Kolkata on October 3.

We have informed FIFA and officials are aware of why we were forced to take this decision."

"As discussed in the executive committee meeting, India have played four times in last three years against Singapore and Malaysia (group opponents at the ASEAN Cup) and may get opportunities to play against them again but Brazil happens, perhaps one in a lifetime for Indian players. It's something that can promote the sport across our country."

The ASEAN Cup is an impor-

tant competition that raised a lot of interest. We will miss that but we will make the best use of this FIFA international window so that India can play two more friendly matches against quality opponents. Teams who are much higher ranked than India. We can learn a lot from such matches.

Jay Gupta scored the first goal for the first FIFA ASEAN Cup and had been grouped with hosts Indonesia, Malaysia and Singapore. The tournament will start on September 21-October 6. India play Brazil in Kolkata on October 3.

East Bengal beat Al Arabi
East Bengal produced a stunning comeback to beat Kuwait's Al Arabi SC 4-1 in extra time of the AFC Champions League Two.

Jay Gupta scored the first goal for the first FIFA ASEAN Cup and had been grouped with hosts Indonesia, Malaysia and Singapore. The tournament will start on September 21-October 6. India play Brazil in Kolkata on October 3.

South Africa is striving to steadily increase the volume of its Test calendar. The upcoming Australian tour of South Africa is expected to generate enough buzz around the Sandpaper Gate storyline. The year-ending England tour of South Africa, however, is not proving to be as lucrative as thought, with leading English broadcaster Sky looking away.

The ICC is known to be looking closely at adding more meaning to the WTC. There is an acknowledgement that currently the conversation centres around the WTC concept only closer to the final. The average fan is not as engaged with the idea of the championship throughout the two-year cycle. Whether the improvement comes in the form of a change in points system remains to be seen.

While future strategies are being drawn, the focus is to keep cricket's most prestigious product alive. The caveat is that Test cricket needs to be "right-sized", according to a key official, "cricket for everyone continues to be seen as just a utopian idea."

DICKWELLA BACK IN SL TEST SQUAD; MAIDEN CALL-UP FOR NUWANTHA

Press Trust of India
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GALLE: Wicketkeeper-batter Niroshan Dickwella returned to Sri Lanka's red-ball set up after three years, away off-spinner Keshara Nuwantha earned his maiden call-up as the hosts named a 16-member squad for the first Test against India.

Dickwella, who last played a Test against New Zealand in 2023, is in line to make his return after regular wicketkeeper Kusal Mendis was ruled out with an injury.

Besides Nuwantha, uncapped batter Pasindu Sooriyabandara and left-arm pacer Dilshan Madushanka have also been included in the squad, which features four specialist fast bowlers. Madushanka's return adds further variety to Sri Lanka's pace attack, which also comprises Asitha Fernando, Lahiru Kumara and Vishwa Fernando. All-rounder Milan Rathnayake provides another seam-bowling option.

Nuwantha, meanwhile, could make his Test debut after building an impressive record in domestic cricket.

The right-arm off-spinner joins left-arm spinner Prabath Jayasuriya and Ramesh Mendis in the spin department.

The squad also includes experienced all-rounders Kamindu Mendis and Dhananjaya de Silva.

Dhananjaya de Silva leads the side while Kamindu Mendis will act as his deputy.

The first Test against India begins here on Saturday.

Why WTC expansion didn't get enough support

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MUMBAI: As the second half of the World Test Championship's (WTC) fourth edition gets rolling, the jury is still out on whether it has left Test cricket in a better place. For all its faults, what however cannot be denied is that the nine-team WTC arrangement has helped Test cricket survive the surfeit of T20.

After strong criticism of the lopsided playing roster, the cricket ecosystem has come to terms with the reality that only better-off cricket boards will be able to host more Test cricket.

It was reasoned that current champions South Africa earning a shot at the title after playing a bare minimum of 12 Tests was less than ideal from a competition standpoint. That said, if cricket boards were forced to take on more Test obligations, there is a fear they would potentially end up with even lesser control over their players and tie them to the T20 franchise landscape.

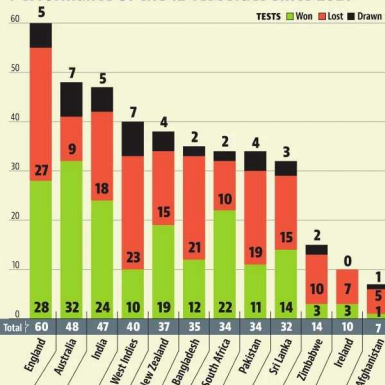
Starting with the Australia-Bangladesh and India-Sri Lanka series this week, Test cricket is entering an unofficial window where 21 WTC matches would be played over the next five months. Concurrently, cricket officials are working overtime for a crucial Future Tours Program meet next month where details will be fleshed out for approval in the November ICC Board meeting on how the game would be spread across formats in the next four-year cycle.

A lopsided distribution of Tests played

Tests played by countries in the last 5 years



Performance of the 12 Test sides since 2021



Next four-year cycle. 12-team WTC expansion unlikely

The proposed WTC expansion to involve all 12 full member nations is set to be given a thumbs down, HT learns. The idea was suggested by an ICC working group headed by Cricket New Zealand's Roger

Twose, but it hasn't got wide-spread support internally. That's down to pure economics. Newest Test nations Ireland and Afghanistan are known to hold the view that hosting even one-off Test series would prove commercially unviable. As per industry estimates, hosting a

Test involves costs in the range of \$1 million. For smaller nations, unless the opposing team were India, or for a few others, England, recovering costs through broadcast is out of the question.

Cricketers Zimbabwe, however, is known to be pushing for a WTC berth. They played 11

Tests last year and even struck an arrangement for the England Cricket Board to pay them touring fees for their away Test.

The critique against Ireland and Afghanistan is that they have done little with their Test status despite enjoying increased funding benefits. In

Afghanistan's case, however, increased costs of an adopted home present a unique challenge.

There's the other argument: a lack of competition with uneven match-ups turns fans away. The India-Afghanistan one-off Test in New Chandigarh played under the hot June sun had

sparse crowd. Afghanistan batters were bowled out twice in 94.3 overs inside three days.

While the fine print on the shape and form of the next WTC is still being worked out, it is understood that the present arrangement of allocating member boards to strike bilateral deals based on commercial viability will continue. Only India, England and Australia currently play five-Test series among themselves on a home-and-away basis.

DPL: South Delhi trump East Delhi

HT Correspondent

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NEW DELHI: Riding on an all-round show, South Delhi Superstars raced to a comfortable nine-wicket victory over East Delhi Riders in Wednesday's Delhi Premier League fixture at the Arun Jaitley Stadium, Delhi.

Chasing 192, Sanat Sangwan and Anmol Sharma stitched together a vital 113-run opening partnership. At no point did the duo look troubled. Sangwan scored 57 off 33, laced with six fours and three sixes before being dismissed by Rounak Waghela in the eleventh over. After his dismissal, captain Ayush Badoni (89*) combined with Anmol (65*) to stitch an unbeaten 81-run partnership to guide their team through.

Earlier, Anshuman Hooda was the standout bowler for South Delhi Superstars, having picked up 4/34 in four overs. Sujal Singh helped East Delhi Riders produce an impressive 191/6 in 20 overs. The total was built around a series of aggressive contributions, with the middle order ensuring the team maintained momentum throughout.

Sujal was the standout performer, remaining unbeaten on 63 from 39 deliveries. He struck six



Anshuman Hooda. DCCA

four and three sixes during a fluent innings that combined control with attacking strokeplay. His ability to find the boundary regularly helped East Delhi Riders maintain a strong scoring rate and provided the foundation for a big finish.

At the top of the order, Vansh Mehra gave the innings firepower with 27 off 16. Arpit Rana continued the attack, scoring 34 from 23 deliveries with six boundaries. The duo stitched a 58-run partnership off 35 balls at the top of the order.

Wicket-keeper batter Suryansh Raina added another crucial contribution with 38 off 26 balls. His six fours and one six kept the pressure on the opposition and ensured the innings never lost momentum. Deepak Punia finished unbeaten on 12 from just six, hitting a four and a six. His late cameo helped push the total beyond 190 but in vain.

Pragg beats Sindarov in Rd 2 of Sinquefield Cup

HT Correspondent

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BENGALURU: R Praggnanandhaa took down World Championship challenger Jovakhir Sindarov in the second round of the Sinquefield Cup. In a game that lasted six hours and 95 moves, Pragg, playing White, kept up the pressure, before Sindarov blundered on move 82 and Pragg didn't let the opportunity slip.

The 21-year-old Indian grandmaster, who won Norway Chess in June and the Saint Louis Rapid and Blitz last week, appears to be in fine form with titles across formats.

Praggnanandhaa and Sindarov have been duelling since their junior years, with their

rivalry gaining a fresh dimension at the Candidates tournament earlier this year. Praggnanandhaa lost both his games against the Uzbek GM at the Candidates, which Sindarov later described as a crucial turning point that saw him race away with the tournament and become the World Championship challenger. Sindarov will face reigning world champion Gukesh in the title match in November.

The Sinquefield Cup win is Praggnanandhaa's second victory over Sindarov since the Candidates. He had earlier defeated him at the 2026 Super Chess Classic Romania, ending Sindarov's 53-game unbeaten streak.

At peace with himself, Patil eyes a second coming at Asiad

Shantanu Srivastava

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NEW DELHI: Process is the word most elite shooters use while dissecting their seemingly static sport. Somewhere in the finite moments between breaths and beats lurks the perfect nanosecond to pull the trigger. Finding it — therein lies the 'process' — holds the key to a perfect 10.9, and yet, on a given day, even that might not suffice. The perfect shot may not be perfect on the given day if it's not fired at the perfect moment.

Submitting yourself to those variables and still finding the drive to keep shooting, hour after hour, year after year requires an obsessive, even meditative, pursuit. If you spoke to Rudranksh Balasubrahmaniam three years back, you'd know you're conversing with a proverbial shooting monk.

"I was a nerd going into my first Asian Games. I would worry about every tangible and intangible variable. I wanted to be in complete control — of my emotions, weapon, body, and results. It works well in an ideal world, but not always in high-pressure competitions," said Rudranksh. "I realised it was taking a lot out of me. My brain was fried."

And so, he went on a course correction. That involved shedding 13kgs, picking up the 50m 3 Positions discipline, changing his equipment, and making peace with inevitable failures. Now, just weeks off his second Asian Games, he describes his mindset as "relaxed, at peace, and quiet." "I am still learning to be in complete control of my mind and body. I try to be a bit dispassionate with the results."

Rudranksh went to the 2023 edition of Asian Games in Hangzhou as the junior-most male shooter in a young team. His teammates — Divyansh Singh Panwar and Aishwary Pratap Singh Tomar — though only a few years older to him, had been to an Olympics each. Only 19 and already the 10m air rifle world champion, Rudranksh landed in Hangzhou nervous and wide-eyed. Among his goals, besides winning an individual medal, was to meet javelin ace Neeraj Chopra. None materialised.

He finished fourth after a

Gunning for the bullseye

Former world champion Rudranksh Patil has had a patchy run over the past couple of years. As he prepares for his second Asian Games, a look at his recent returns:

SINCE ASIAN GAMES 2023

IN 10 METRE AIR RIFLE INDIVIDUAL EVENT

WORLD C'SHIPS	WORLD CUP FINAL
13th (2025)	13th (2023) 4th (2025)

WORLD CUPS

Gold in Buenos Aires, 2025
8th in Lima, 2025
11th in Cairo, 2024
18th in Munich, 2024
30th in Munich, 2026
18th in Hangzhou, 2026

ASIAN CHAMPIONSHIPS

Gold in New Delhi, 2026
4th in Shymkent, 2025
Bronze in Jakarta, 2024

IN 50 METRE 3P INDIVIDUAL EVENT

9th in Asian Championships, 2026
18th in Hangzhou World Cup, 2026
53rd in Munich World Cup, 2026

CURRENT WORLD RANKING

21 10m air rifle	73 50m 3P
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shoot-off with Tomar and the meeting with Chopra never happened. Things are a bit different this time. "I am a changed man now. I don't obsess over things anymore. As individual as this sport is, your results also depend on how the person next to you is shooting. With time, you tend to dismiss those thoughts and get on with it. I'll have my hands full at the Asiad this time, so I won't be seeking out anyone to meet or get a picture with," Rudranksh, who will be competing in the 50m 3P, 10m individual, mixed team, and men's team competitions, said.

"There will be four medal opportunities, so it's important to find the right balance going into the competition. It's still an area I am working on."

The three years since Hangzhou have been instructive for the youngster. He won a bronze at the 2024 Asian Championships, missed the berth for Paris Olympics after holding the quota for two years, and went on a prolonged slump.

Soon enough, the individual medals dried up, and the World Cup gold at the Buenos Aires last April began to appear a pleasant anomaly. A modicum of redemption arrived this February with the Asian Championships gold in 10m in Delhi, but it has been a medalless run since.

"It's been a tough year, but

that's also because I have been trying out a few things. I am still figuring out the balance between the two events," he said.

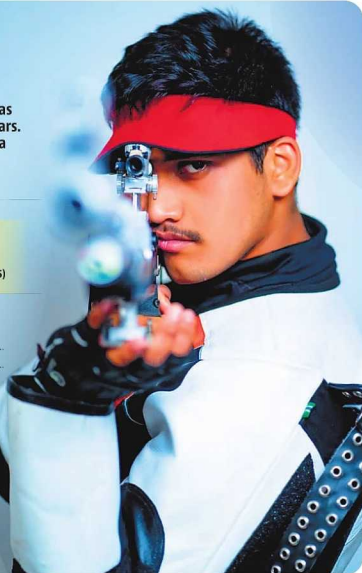
It's not easy to juggle the two disciplines. The equipment, ammunition, range, rules and recoil are all different, and it takes a complete reorientation of sorts for a shooter to nail consistent competitive scores in both.

"The 50m event requires a lot more body relaxation and you need to be tuned-in in three positions. The 10m can get a bit monotonous for the body, and as a result, body craves to break the pattern," he said.

Among his elementary challenges was to cut his weight. Then

weighing 96kgs, Rudranksh lost 13kgs in three months to avoid putting excessive pressure on his knees. Having maintained that weight for about two years now, he is in the process of a body transformation — losing fat and gaining muscle while keeping the bodyweight constant.

He works out thrice a week and goes on the occasional 5km run. "Despite my weight, I have always been fond of running and I have been competing in local 5km and 10km events even before I took up shooting. It helps me clear my head," he said. Ask what his go-to relaxation technique was three years back. "To shoot more. I was hopeless," he laughed.



Lakers to be sold for \$12.5 bn: ESPN

WASHINGTON: The Los Angeles Lakers — one of the most successful teams in NBA history — are being sold to former Disney CEO Bob Iger and investor Joshua Kushner in a deal valued at the team at \$12.5 billion, ESPN reported. The sale, which would mark a record-breaking price, comes only about a year after billionaire Mark Walter agreed to buy a controlling interest in the team in a then-record \$10 billion deal.

Ministry suspends table tennis body

NEW DELHI: The Sports Ministry suspended its recognition of the Table Tennis Federation of India and asked IOA to form an ad hoc panel to administer the sport, citing governance deficiencies within TTFI. The TTFI is currently led by Meghna Ahlawat, wife of Haryana MLA Dushyant Chautala. TTFI made headlines when Manika Batra was left out of the Asian Games squad, citing lack of requisite game time.

Ronaldo, Georgina tie the knot

LISBON: Cristiano Ronaldo and Georgina Rodriguez are husband and wife. They married on Tuesday in a civil ceremony described by his public relations team as "a private and intimate moment attended by their five children." The ceremony took place in Cascais, near Lisbon. They have been together for the past decade after meeting in Madrid.

Kaul in clubhouse lead on rainy Day 2

KOLKATA: Delhi golfer Kshitij Naveed Kaul's four-under 66 took him into sole lead of the Coal India Open on a rain-hit second day at the Tolly Club, Kaul, 25, aggregated 10-under 130 with almost half of the 132-player field yet to finish their round when play was halted.

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